

Toll from BNP-M rally blast rises to 15

By Saleem Shahid

QUETTA: The death toll from a suicide bombing at the BNP-M rally at Shahwani Stadium a day earlier rose to 15, as two of the 36 victims being treated at the Civil Hospital died on Wednesday.

The blast, which struck after supporters, workers and leaders of BNP, NP, PTI, PkMAP and ANP gathered at Shahwani

**A new threat:
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Stadium to mark the fourth death anniversary of veteran nationalist leader Sardar Attaullah Mengal, also left dozens injured.

A faction of the militant Islamic State (IS) group claimed responsibility for the attack and also released a photo of the suicide bomber.

PM Shehbaz Sharif and leaders of the Tehreek-i-Tahaffuz Ayeen-i-Pakistan (TTAP) and National Party condemned the explosion, with the latter alleging that it was an “attempt to pressurise political

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IHC adopts new rules by razor-thin majority

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• CJ turns down plea by some judges to postpone meeting as they haven't had a chance to review the voluminous document • Move to have family courts hear polygamy cases gets full court nod

By Malik Asad

ISLAMABAD: Despite strong resistance from senior judges, a full court meeting of the Islamabad High Court (IHC) on Wednesday adopted the High Court Establishment (Appointment and Conditions of Service) Rules, 2025.

The rules were passed by a slim majority, while a proposal from two judges, seeking changes to the meeting's agenda, was rejected.

According to the agenda, the full court had been convened to deliberate on three key issues: amendments to the law related to polygamy, structural flaws in the IHC building, and the adoption of the service rules.

The meeting was attended by all 11 judges, including

Chief Justice Sardar Mohammad Sarfraz Dogar, Justice Mohsin Akhtar Kayani, Justice Tariq Mehmood Jahangiri, Justice Babar Sattar, Justice Arbab Mohammad Tahir, Justice Sardar Ejaz Ish-

SCBA for open hearing of complaints against judges: Page 3

aq Khan, Justice Khadim Husain Soomro, Justice Saman Rafat Imtiaz, Justice Mohammad Azam Khan, Justice Mohammad Asif, and Justice Raja Inaam Ameen Minhas.

Polygamy law, building flaws

Sources said the full court unanimously approved the amendment to the polygamy law, under which such cases will now be tried by family

courts instead of executive magistrates.

It also decided to refer the IHC building case to the federal government for a thorough investigation into persistent issues. An inquiry conducted by the public works department earlier pointed out several defects in the elevators.

The inquiry report noted that the elevators lacked certain features promised in the prototype and the specifications, but it failed to identify those responsible for the faulty installation and maintenance.

Apart from the elevators, the IHC building continues to suffer from multiple problems, including an ineffective cooling system and inadequate parking facilities for

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Dual flood threat to Muzaffargarh and Multan

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- Preparations in place for more 'controlled breaches' as waters from Ravi-Chenab set to converge
- PDMA chief fears renewed flooding in central Punjab as Indian dams near max capacity; says 'Ravi flowing backwards' instead of merging with Chenab
- 3.7m affected across province, death toll jumps to 46; another massive surge expected at Multan tomorrow

By Imran Gabol

LAHORE: As the confluence of the swollen Ravi and Chenab rivers near Khanewal threatens the districts of Multan and Muzaffargarh, provincial authorities on Wednesday braced for an unprecedented disaster in light of a "dual threat", which persisted despite several controlled breaches over the past week.

The water level at Muhammadwala and Sher Shah was recorded at 412 feet, only five feet below critical level. The authorities termed the next 12 hours critical, as

the pressure at the breaching points continued to increase

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US lawmakers briefed on flood devastation in Pakistan: Page 5

Five killed as heavy rain lashes northern India: Page 12

Floods damaged vast areas of farmland in KP: UN-OCHA: Page 12

after the convergence of the Ravi and Chenab rivers near Khanewal.

In order to save urban centres along the eastern rivers, the Punjab government has been following a policy of controlled breaches to relieve pressure on barrages and main embankments to protect densely populated cities. A decision on whether to conduct a breach at Head Muhammadwala, Sher Shah Flood Bund, and Rangpur is expected within hours to save Multan and Muzaffargarh, with 17 points identified.

However, the situation in these two districts is compounded because of an enormous surge of approximately

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KASUR: Water surrounds the home of a flood-affected man as far as the eye can see, after heavy rain caused the level of the Sutlej River to rise again.—AFP

Why breaching is 'not an option' for Sindh

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Minister says Punjab's strategy can't be emulated downstream due to province's peculiar topography

By Mohammad Hussain Khan
in Hyderabad

AS PUNJAB continues to use breaches to divert water from its overflowing rivers, Sindh may not be able to emulate this strategy due to its unique topography, with the minister con-

cerned categorically ruling out this option.

Over the past week, authorities in Punjab have destroyed several embankments to save major cities from being inundated. Naturally, the Sindh government has been facing queries about whether a similar strategy will be deployed in the province.

The swollen eastern rivers of Ravi, Chenab, and Sutlej merge into the Indus River at Panjnad before entering Sindh, and the province faces a similar situation to the one it faced in September 2014.

The Indus River has already passed a

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Xi offers 'war or peace' as China flexes military might

Page 1

• Putin, Kim, Shehbaz, Pezeshkian among world leaders who witness massive parade in Tiananmen Square • 'Hot mic' catches Xi and Putin discussing biotechnology, prospects of prolonging human life • PM meets Chinese businessmen, tours Beijing's Anzhen Hospital

Dawn Report

BEIJING: President Xi Jinping warned the world was facing a choice between peace or war, as China showcased its military arsenal at a massive parade on Wednesday.

"Today, mankind is faced with the choice of peace or war, dialogue or confrontation, win-win or zero-sum," Xi told a crowd of more than 50,000 spectators at Tiananmen Square, adding that the

Chinese people "firmly stand on the right side of history".

Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif was also in attendance, alongside Russian President Vladimir Putin and North Korean Leader Kim Jong Un, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, and a host of other world leaders.

The event to mark 80 years since Japan's defeat at the end of World War II was designed to project China's military might and diplomatic clout.

It managed to get a rise out



(LEFT to right) Vladimir Putin, Xi Jinping, Kim Jong Un and Shehbaz Sharif are seen arriving together to view a military parade in Beijing.—Reuters

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of US President Donald Trump, who wrote an acidic post on his Truth Social Platform.

"Please give my warmest regards to Vladimir Putin, and Kim Jong Un, as you conspire against the United States of America," Trump added.

The Kremlin said Putin was not conspiring against the United States and suggested Trump was being ironic in his remarks.

Military hardware and a 'hot mic'

Riding in an open-top limou-

sine, Xi then inspected the troops and cutting-edge military equipment such as hypersonic missiles, underwater drones and a weaponised 'robot wolf'.

Helicopters trailing large banners and fighter jets flew in formation during a 70-minute showcase that culminated in the release of 80,000 'peace' birds.

New underwater drones and supersonic missiles counted among the gear on display, as

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Illegal auction of vehicles: FIA arrests two Customs officials

LAHORE: The Federal Investigation Agency (FIA) has arrested two Customs officials for their alleged involvement in the illegal auction of vehicles.

The FIA said on Wednesday that Deputy Collector Maryam Jameela and Assistant Collector Naeem Raza of the Customs Department in collusion with other associates created fake customs auction IDs.

"They have been found involved in generating fraudulent IDs, making fake entries, and conducting bogus verifications of vehicles. They were also committing fraud in collaboration with the Motor Registration Authority and private individuals," the FIA said.

NCCIA: The National Cyber Crime Investigation Agency (NCCIA) has arrested another YouTuber, Mudassar Hassan, for his alleged involvement in "unregulated online trading and gambling online apps".

"The accused person is involved in promoting illegal online betting apps via YouTube and other social media tools," it said.

A case has been registered against the suspect. The NCCIA has already arrested YouTuber Saadur Rehman, popularly known as Ducky Bhai, for allegedly promoting the gambling apps encouraging the youth to invest in schemes that lack regulatory approval. — **Staff Reporter**

IGP summoned in woman's abduction case

Page 2

LAHORE: The Lahore High Court on Wednesday summoned the Punjab inspector general of police (IGP) in a petition seeking recovery of a woman allegedly abducted six years ago.

During the proceedings, CCPO Bilal Siddique Kamyana, DIG Investigation Zeeshan Raza and other police officers appeared before the court.

The CCPO submitted a report on efforts made for the recovery of the woman. He stated that the police had undertaken extensive efforts in the case.

Chief Justice Aalia Neelum observed that there was no such woman who cannot be traced by the police. She noted that the alleged abducted woman was a housewife.

The CCPO said that the woman did not even possess a mobile phone that could be tracked. He pointed out that two rounds of investigations had already been completed and a third inquiry was currently underway.

Being dissatisfied with the police efforts, Chief Justice Neelum remarked that it appeared reports were being drafted sitting in the office instead of fieldwork. The CJ directed the IGP to personally appear in the court on Thursday (today).

A counsel for the petitioner, Hameedan Bibi, pointed out that an FIR had been registered against the victim's husband and mother-in-law six years ago, but she had still not been recovered. — Staff Reporter

Drones used to hit katcha area dacoits

Page 2

RAHIM YAR KHAN: Punjab police conducted a 'surprise' operation against dacoits in Katcha Ronti using modern drone technology.

"Several hideouts and shelters of dacoits were destroyed through drones, while reports of multiple dacoits being injured have also been received," the police spokesperson said. He said a targeted operation was carried out to recover some individuals held hostage by criminals.

"Under the leadership of DPO Khan Irfan Ali Samo, the hideouts of the dacoits in the riverine area were targeted through drones," an official handout said. — **Correspondent**

Theme Park owner arrested for raising illegal scheme in Ravi

ACE seeks record from Ruda, LDA: promises strict action

By Zulqernain Tahir

LAHORE: The Anti-Corruption Establishment (ACE) has arrested the owner of Theme Park, an 'illegal' housing scheme raised in the river bed of Ravi.

The scheme was completely inundated by the swollen river last week.

"Khushi Muhammad built this illegal housing scheme in the Ravi land, made residential plots on 12,000 kanals inside the river bed and sold them to citizens by fraud. The suspect had not built the society as per law and even couldn't establish any kind of sewage system in the fake housing scheme and since the entire area was inside the river, therefore, all the houses in the illegal housing scheme were submerged by the floodwater," an ACE spokesperson said in a statement on Wednesday.

He said the ACE had also sought record of all illegal housing schemes

established in the Ravi bed from the River Urban Development Authority (Ruda) and the Lahore Development Authority (LDA) so that action could be taken against those housing schemes as per the law.

"Theme Park was not approved by the relevant departments. Keeping in mind public complaints, the ACE has decided to take strict action against all such illegal housing schemes which are established on river land," he said and added the construction of housing societies on river land could not be permitted at all and indiscriminate action would be taken against already-established illegal housing schemes as well.

A source said Khushi Muhammad was a police constable before he kicked off this project -- Theme Park -- with a small piece of land. "By exploiting the loopholes in the system and greasing the palm of the officials concerned, he continued acquiring more land in the river bed and sold the same to the citizens. He also managed to transfer billions of rupees abroad.

Interestingly, it is the National Accountability Bureau (NAB) which usually initiates action against the housing

societies involved in fraudulent activities but in this case the ACE stepped in first.

"It will be a test case for Punjab Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz whether she successfully lays hands on those involved in this mega corruption housing scam along the river bed or buckles under the pressure of those who have strong connections in certain corridors," an official source said and added not only the owners of such societies but top officials in bureaucracy that helped them build structures on the river land with impunity should be taken to task.

Federal Minister for Communication Aleem Khan, also the president of Istehkam-i-Pakistan Party (IPP) which was dubbed as king's party at the time of its inception in 2023, had got a major relief same year following NAB's decision to close an inquiry against him for allegedly occupying and encroaching public passages and illegal extension of the Park View housing society both in Lahore and Islamabad under the new accountability laws. The property tycoon was accused of illegally occupying 'public passages' and illegal extension of River Edge Housing Society Lahore and

also illegal extension of a housing society (Park View) in Islamabad, thus minting money from general public by selling plots in unapproved phases.

The LDA had raised an objection saying the housing scheme was situated in a river area which could not be utilised for any residential purposes. "It is not safe for the people's lives to allow residential construction there (Ravi area)," the LDA had informed NAB.

"The land also fell in an agricultural area and did not carry the characteristics of urban property thus the scheme was not approved. Despite this, Aleem Khan and others started selling the plots falling in the area for which approval was refused," NAB had alleged. It is a big question mark how come RUDA, LDA or TMAs approved structures along the river bed.

In recent days, billions of rupees of residents have been lost in various housing schemes and katchi abadis after floodwater entered their houses and business premises in Lahore. This area comes under the Ravi Riverfront Urban Development Project being executed along a 46km long stretch of Ravi by RUDA.

Surging Dek breaches dyke at two points

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Flood-tossed villagers irked by photo sessions during food and fodder distribution

By Abid Mahmood

NAROWAL: High-level flooding in the Dek rain drain has wreaked havoc in Zafarwal, leading to the collapse of protective dyke at two points.

The powerful floodwaters have washed away dozens of houses and shops, leaving many residents displaced and forcing them to spend nights under the open sky with their families and livestock. The fast-moving deluge, caused by heavy monsoon rains in Pakistan, India, and Occupied Kashmir, also cut off many villages from land access as the Ravi swelled.

For the past fortnight, the floodwater from Occupied Kashmir had been causing rapid land erosion along the Dek rain drain.

Despite efforts by local residents, the district administration, and the irrigation department to reinforce protective embankments, the flood that hit on Tuesday night proved too strong. The embankments broke at two points in the villages of Lahri and

Skroor, causing floodwater to pour into fields and residential areas.

The breach has submerged thousands of acres of agricultural land. A five-kilometre stretch of road connecting the villages of Deoli, Skroor, and over a dozen other communities has been washed away. More than two dozen shops, a cemetery, and numerous houses have been swept away. The floodwater has accumulated up to three to four feet deep inside homes and government buildings.

Farhan Ijaz, a journalist from Zafarwal, reported that more than 300 families are currently in relief camps. He spoke of the severe difficulties faced by flood victims who are irked by 'photo sessions' during distribution of items.

According to Ijaz, victims have refused to accept food and fodder for their animals during these staged events. They said they are facing difficulties cooking meals at home and are seeking help, not a media spectacle. The journalist said land erosion continues rapidly along the Dek drain.

Local MPA Ahmed Iqbal, who chairs the Public Accounts Committee of Punjab, confirmed the scale of the disaster, stating the drain had breached by 2,000 feet. He explained that the Dek drain has carved a new path through farmers' fields, submerging thousands of acres of farmland and livestock shelters. Iqbal spoke of the critical shortage of fodder for animals and the disruption of land communication between villages and the city.

He said this is the third major flood wave to hit the area, and emergency measures are being taken to pro-

tect citizens. Cooked food and aid packages are being provided to those in relief camps. In response to the victims' pleas, they have demanded that Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz ban the practice of taking pictures during the distribution of food and fodder. The water level in the Ravi has risen from 60,000 to 90,000 cusecs and continues to increase. The rising water has cut off land access to villages like Dawood, Bheenian, and Raiya Khas. Floodwater has accumulated on the Narowal-Shakargarh Road, disrupting traffic. Rescue 1122 teams are actively working to shift people and animals to safe locations along the embankments of the New Lahore Road and Narowal-Shakargarh Road.

Narowal Deputy Commissioner Syed Hassan Raza visited the protective embankments and flood relief camps, instructing the irrigation department to strengthen and monitor the infrastructure. He distributed food and inspected the quality of aid being provided. Rana Jahangir, a spokesperson for the Gujranwala Electric Power Supply Company (Gepco), reported that a 132 kV transmission line tower collapsed due to the flood, suspending power to 16 feeders from the Zafarwal grid station. Gepco employees have managed to partially restore power to nine feeders by using alternative sources, but a new tower will need to be installed once the water level subsides. The restored feeders include 11 KV Zafarwal, Rahimabad, Jammu Gate, Tharo Mandi, Noonar, Dham Thal, Kangra, Gigian and Bhagyari feeders. He said work is underway to restore other feeders from alternative sources. He said that a new tower will be installed when the water level in the Dek drain decreases.

Breach at Sultan Bahu Bridge wreaks havoc

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316,500 acres of farmland affected by floodwater in Jhang district

By Tariq Saeed

TOBA TEK SINGH: A breach at the Sultan Bahu Bridge caused by the water coming from the Trimmu Headworks on the River Chenab has played havoc with Ahmadpur Sial tehsil in Jhang district.

As per details, due to the breach almost all the villages around the Ahmadpur Sial city have been inundated and the floodwater also entered the Garh Maharaja town. However, floodwater had not reached the Ahmadpur Sial city till the filing of this report.

Journalists in Ahmadpur Sial told *Dawn* that Jhang-Multan-Muzaffargarh Road was closed for traffic and the Chenab's water was flowing over it.

They said that several localities

of Samundana area adjacent to the river Ravi had been badly affected as floodwater of both rivers, Ravi and Chenab, was gathered there. Fields and houses had been damaged because of this, they added.

Jhang district administration, in a press release, said a total of 316,500 acres of farmland had been affected by the floodwater in the district. Out of these, crops on 261,859 acres had been inundated by the floodwater.

The statement said that out of the total 274 flood-affected localities, 137 were in Jhang tehsil, 37 in Athara Hazari tehsil, 41 in Shorkot tehsil and 58 in Ahmadpur Sial tehsil.

It said that 358,261 people had been shifted to safer places from affected areas and the affectees had been provided with 63,000 food boxes and 3,500 food hampers.

Meanwhile, the family of PTI Central Information Secretary and MNA from Jhang, Sheikh Waqqas Akram, claimed that on the direction of PTI founder Imran Khan, they had arranged six relief camps

in flood-hit areas.

They said they had rescued 850 people from various localities and provided free medical check up of 1,200 people in their medical camp.

RAIL SERVICE SUSPENDED: All train traffic for Karachi from Faisalabad has been suspended after the bridge at Abdul Hakim came under floodwater.

The floodwater from Ravi caused havoc after its Mai Safooran spur located in Pirmahal tehsil was blasted by army team when water discharge level in Ravi exceeded 172,000 cusec against the capacity of 150,000 cusec late on Tuesday night. It inundated dozens of villages in Pirmahal and Abdul Hakim tehsils.

At Kamalia, water flow level in Ravi had lowered and repair work of two broken roads, Kamalia-Chichawatni and Kamalia-Harapa roads, was in progress.

However, traffic remained suspended for a third consecutive day. The Pirmahal-Abdul Hakim Road had also been closed for traffic as Ravi's floodwater was flowing over it.

SCBA for open hearing of complaints against judges

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Set of proposals made public ahead of SC full court meeting

By Nasir Iqbal

ISLAMABAD: As the scheduled full court meeting of the top court is fast approaching for giving a final approval to the Supreme Court Rules, the Supreme Court Bar Association (SCBA) has proposed open inquiries into complaints by the Supreme Judicial Council (SJC) against superior court judges.

In a set of proposals, the SCBA highlighted that open hearings will not only ensure internal accountability but also reaffirm the constitutional guarantee of equality before law under Article 25 and the right to fair trial under Article 10A of the Constitution.

Once a complaint is admitted, the SJC should conduct open proceedings subject to reasonable safeguards of dignity and decorum while deciding references within a fixed timeframe, preferably six months.

The 12-page set of proposals seeking to amend the SC Rules-2025 was furnished by SCBA President Mian Mohammad Rauf Atta and senior advocate Hafiz Ehsan Khokhar and were made known to the media at a press conference on Wednesday.

Considering the adverse reaction by the top lawyer's bodies including the Pakistan Bar Council (PBC) and SCBA, Chief Justice of Pakistan (CJP) Yahya Afridi had constituted a committee under Rule 1(4) of the new rules to suggest recommendations for addressing any difficulty that may arise in giving effect to provisions of the new rules.

The proposals will be taken up by the full court on Sept 8.

The written proposals request immediate withdrawal of recent increase in court fees, setting up a timeline for lawyers representing different parties to present arguments, deciding every case filed in the Supreme Court within a year, issuing orders of court proceedings the same day and reserved decisions within a month.

According to the set of proposals, suggestions were made to ensure the implementation of legal provisions under Articles 4, 10A, 25, and 37(d) that guarantee equality before law, fair trial, and the right to inexpensive and expeditious justice.

It was noted that as SC's sanctioned strength has been enhanced to 35 judges, including the

CJP, this moment presents a unique opportunity for structural reforms.

The key reform proposals include rationalisation of court fees, stating the recent increase in court fees should be withdrawn to ensure inexpensive justice, as seen in Norway and Germany where only nominal fees were charged.

One of the proposals deals with the right of audience for counsel by ensuring uninterrupted opportunities for lawyers to present their case, similar to structured models in Norway, France and Germany, while another asked for increase in working hours and urgent benches of the court as practised in India, the UK and the US.

The right of access to justice enshrined in Articles 4 and 10A of the Constitution requires not merely the availability of judicial forums but also their effective and timely functioning, it was emphasised.

The pendency of cases before the SC that had reached unprecedented levels demands innovative approaches to maximise court's productivity. One effective reform would be the extension of working hours for hearings and the creation of "late benches" dedicated to urgent matters such as bail, human rights petitions, election disputes and stay applications. Comparative practices illustrate that this model has proven highly effective in other jurisdictions, the proposal said, adding the Supreme Court of India regularly constitutes vacation benches and late benches to address urgent relief during recess and after-hours sittings.

For Pakistan, the adoption of extended hours and urgent benches would not only address the backlog but also reinforce public confidence in the judiciary's responsiveness, thereby fulfilling the constitutional promise that justice will be administered without delay or denial.

Another proposal stated the Articles 175 and 184 envisioned the Supreme Court as the apex judicial authority, with mandate to adjudicate matters of constitutional, tax, civil, criminal, and regulatory importance.

On cause list and adjournment of cases, the proposal asked for adopting India's continuous listing and China's AI-driven scheduling to curb adjournments.

It asked for the issuance of short orders the same day followed by detailed reasons, consistent with the practice in Germany, Türkiye, and France.

About digitisation, it asked for e-filing, online tracking, and automation modelled on systems in Singapore, China, and Norway.

'Dual flood threat'

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550,000 cusecs that crossed the Marala and Khanki Headworks and was recorded passing through Qadirabad Headworks with an intensity of 530,000 cusecs. Officials projected that this powerful surge would reach Trimmu Headworks on Thursday and is expected to arrive in the Multan region by Friday.

"The next 12 hours are extremely critical," stated a Provincial Disaster Management Authority (PDMA) official closely involved in crisis management. "We are facing a dual threat: the existing high water from the confluence of the rivers and a new, massive wave heading directly for us. All resources are being mobilised," he said.

On the other hand, the railway traffic to Karachi and vice versa was suspended from Faisalabad after a bridge on a railway track on the Chenab River came under water in Abdul Hakim.

Flood warnings

In a press conference on Wednesday evening, PDMA Director General Irfan Ali Kathia said that the flood crisis was set to intensify as all three major Indian dams were expected to reach their maximum capacity within the next 72 hours, exacerbating an already catastrophic situation in the Punjab river system. Addressing a press conference, DG Kathia revealed that his office had received three separate flood warnings in the past 24 hours alone.

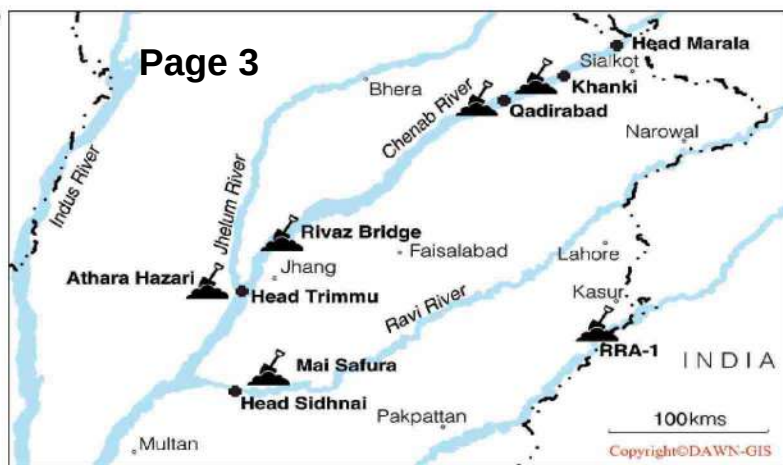
He confirmed that while the water level in the Chenab River was currently stable, previously affected districts along its course were likely to face renewed flooding.

The Sutlej River has been in a flood-like condition for the past two months, while the Ravi River was experiencing rising levels at the Jassar monitoring point. "The next 72 hours are critical," he stated.

"Thein Dam is already full and will continue to release water into the Ravi for the next two to three weeks. While the situation in Ravi will not be as severe as before, water levels will definitely increase."

In an alarming development, the DG explained that instead of merging with the Chenab as normally expected, the Ravi's waters are flowing backwards, preventing any decrease in its water levels. "Until water levels decrease at Ahmadpur Sial, we will not see any reduction at Sidhnai," he clarified.

The presser came after Punjab CM Maryam Nawaz conducted a personal assessment of the critical Head



THIS map shows the locations of controlled breaches, carried out by authorities so far to save major urban centres in Punjab. According to PDMA, arrangements are in place to breach more dykes at Head Muhammadwala, Shershah and Rangpur.

Muhammadwala site. DG Kathia said they were facing a major challenge here because it had only four to five feet of capacity remaining before reaching critical levels.

"At Sher Shah Bridge in Multan, there's significant water pressure with only a two-foot margin remaining," he revealed. "Important decisions regarding a controlled breaching in Multan have already been made to prevent uncontrolled overflow."

Speaking about the damage, the DG said that more than 3,900 villages and a population exceeding 3.7 million had been affected across Punjab. The death toll has risen to 46 people, while over 1.4m residents and 1m animals had been relocated to safer locations.

The relief effort has expanded to include 409 flood camps where all essential facilities are being provided to approximately 25,000 displaced persons currently taking shelter.

In the Khanewal and Toba Tek Singh districts, the flooding has already affected 136 and 75 villages, respectively, with numbers expected to rise in light of renewed surges.

Punjab CM's visit

Earlier, Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz visited flood relief camps in Multan and directed the district administrations to ascertain the scale of damage caused by the floods.

She directed the deputy commissioners to conduct surveys in the flood-affected areas and also provide clean drinking

water. She also ordered fumigation and dry germicidal sprays in the flood relief camps and tent cities in the flood-affected areas.

River flows

As of 11pm on Wednesday night, the Marala Headworks on Chenab reported a flow of 444,754 cusecs, which was falling, while both Khanki (steady) and Qadirabad Headworks (rising) were holding steady with extremely high flows of 558,683 and 557,440 cusecs, respectively.

A point of vigilance was the Chinot bridge, where a rising trend was noted with 291,558 cusecs, and Head Muhammadwala, which was also rising at 413.25 feet against a danger level of 417.50 feet. Rivaz Bridge was steady at 519.90 ft (max level 526 ft) and Trimmu Headworks was steady at 265,837 cusecs.

For the Ravi River, the upstream point at Jassar was falling with 82,140 cusecs, indicating a receding trend.

All subsequent points had stabilised, including Ravi Syphon (79,800 cusecs and rising), Shahdara (78,340 cusecs and rising), Balloki Headworks (114,130 cusecs), and Sidhnai Headworks (152,480 Cusecs and falling), reporting steady conditions.

The Sutlej River system was completely stable across all monitoring stations. Key points included G.S. Wala (319,295 cusecs and steady), Sulemanki Headworks (132,492 cusecs and steady), Islam Headworks (95727 cusecs and steady), Panjnad Headworks (159,662 cusecs and steady), and Malsi Syphon (86,085 cusecs).

Six killed in Kurram vehicle attack

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By Our Correspondent

KURRAM: Six people were shot dead when gunmen opened fire on a vehicle in Mahoora, Lower Kurram, on Thursday, with police linking the killings to a feud between two families.

A senior police official told *Dawn* that the attackers targeted the vehicle going from Para Chamkani to Sadda, near Mahoora village, on the boundary between Upper and Lower Kurram, killing all but one passenger.

"The gunmen have been identified and raids are under way to arrest them," Regional Police Officer Abbas Majeed Marwat said, adding that 24 people from the suspected family had been detained.

"Investigations are at an advanced stage," he said, describing the assault as an act of revenge in a long-running feud. RPO Marwat said that "some miscreants are trying to exploit the incident and provoke sectarian conflict, but we know what this is about and are making efforts to arrest the actual culprits".

Kurram, which borders Afghanistan, has witnessed sporadic sectarian violence in the past, often disrupting traffic on its main route that connects the tribal district with the rest of the country. Such incidents keep both residents and the administration on edge to prevent the situation from spiraling out of control.

Opposition alliance rails against Punjab govt's flood relief efforts

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TTAP accuses officials of using relief efforts to run media campaign for CM

By Ikram Junaidi

ISLAMABAD: The Tehreek-i-Tahaffuz Ayeen-i-Pakistan (TTAP) on Wednesday called the Punjab government's flood relief efforts a failure, accusing officials of prioritising a media campaign for the chief minister over providing aid amid severe flooding.

The remarks were made during a press conference, where leaders of the political alliance criticised the government's response to a natural disaster affecting numerous districts.

"Punjab is also facing severe floods, but the provincial government has completely failed," said TTAP Secretary General Asad Qaiser, who was joined by Salman Akram Raja, Raja Nasir Abbas and others.

"Instructions have been passed that relief activities cannot be done without pictures of Maryam Nawaz. Only media campaign is going on and no relief has been provided."

Mr Qaiser, stating that he also

belongs to a flood-affected area, spoke of the human toll of the disaster. "I also belong to areas affected by flood and know a house in which 13 family members died," he said.

He called for a comprehensive plan to build small dams and suggested that an emergency be declared. Mr Qaiser also blamed illegal housing societies for flooding in Lahore and urged the government to re-launch the Billion Tree Tsunami project to prevent disasters in future.

He contrasted the current situation with the 2022 floods, claiming the former PDM government sought international funds but failed to act. He also alleged the current Punjab government was preoccupied with social media.

"Punjab government was busy on TikTok and was doing nothing," Mr Qaiser said, noting that livestock was suffering without care while officials were making visits to Japan instead of supporting the people.

Salman Akram Raja, who also spoke at the conference, warned of economic consequences. He said destroyed crops would lead to higher prices for rice and wheat.

"The import-export gap has been increasing due to which inflation will increase," Mr Raja said.

Markhor hunting permit breaks record at GB auction

Top permit for Astore markhor sold for \$370,000

By Jamil Nagri

GILGIT: The Gilgit-Baltistan Wildlife and Parks Department auctioned off hunting permits for 118 animals for the 2025–26 season on Wednesday, with the top permit for an Astore markhor fetching \$370,000.

The event took place at the Forest, Parks, and Wildlife Complex in Gilgit, with numerous outfitters and hunters participating in the bidding, during which the department auctioned permits for the trophy hunting of four Astore markhors, 100 Himalayan ibexes, and 14 blue sheep.

The second-highest permit for an Astore markhor sold for \$286,000, while the top permits for a blue sheep and a Himalayan ibex went

for \$40,000 and \$13,000, respectively.

“This is a record for the highest markhor hunting permit bid in the world and in Pakistan,” GB conservator for Parks and Wildlife Khadim Abbas told *Dawn*.

He noted that the previous high-priced permit in Pakistan was auctioned by the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa wildlife department in Chitral last year for \$271,000.

Shikar Safaris Owner Raja Farhad Maqpoon placed the winning \$370,000 bid for a permit in the Nanga Parbat conservancy area.

The other two Astore markhor permits sold for \$270,000 and \$240,000. The highest bids for both the blue sheep and Himalayan ibex permits were won by M Ali Nagri of Markhor Safaris.

For the upcoming season, the department raised the base price for an Astore markhor permit to \$200,000, up from \$150,000 last year.

The base prices for blue sheep and Himalayan ibex were set at

\$30,000 and \$10,000, up from \$9,000 and \$5,500, respectively. In the 2024-25 season, the highest bid for a markhor was \$161,000.

However, some local outfitters and tour operators argued the sharp fee hikes are discouraging international clients and could harm their businesses.

“If the true spirit of conservation is replaced with short-term financial gains for local communities, the model will lose its foundation and is likely to collapse within a few years, leaving both wildlife and communities at a greater loss,” said Ikram Baig, president of the GB Association of Tour Operators.

The trophy hunting programme in Gilgit-Baltistan was launched in 1990 and is credited with helping protect endangered species.

Under the programme, local communities receive about 80 percent of the revenue from hunting permits to be used for conservation and development projects. Stakeholders now fear the latest price hikes could jeopardise its sustainability.

Principal arrested for allegedly raping student

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Dawn Report

RAWALPINDI: The Rawalpindi Police on Wednesday said they had arrested the principal of a private academy over the alleged rape and forced abortion of a Grade 10 student, reported *Dawn.com*.

The student, a resident of Khayaban-i-Sir Syed of Rawalpindi's Pirwadhai town, had lodged a first information report (FIR) with the police on Monday under Sections 338A (punishment for Isqat-i-haml) and 376i (punishment for rape) of the Pakistan Penal Code, alleging that her academy's principal raped her multiple times and forced her to have an abortion.

In her complaint, the victim alleged that the principal, who was childless, had offered to marry her while she was studying in Grade 10.

She reportedly told him to approach her parents regarding the matter.

She further said that the principal started coming closer to her and assured her that he would help her get good marks in the matriculation examination, convincing her to have physical relations with him.

Human Rights Minister Azam Nazeer Tarar earlier ordered an "immediate and transparent" investigation into the incident, according to a statement issued today by Tarar's office. The minister ordered the suspect's immediate arrest and sought a report on the incident. "The provision of justice to the affected student should be ensured under all circumstances," Tarar, who is also the law minister, was quoted as saying.

ATC proceeds to declare 60 PTI workers proclaimed offenders

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ISLAMABAD: Anti-Terrorism Court (ATC) in Islamabad on Wednesday initiated proceedings to declare 60 accused as proclaimed offenders in a case registered at Sangjani police station against Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf (PTI) leaders and workers in connection with a case registered following last year's protest.

ATC Judge Tahir Abbas Sipra conducted hearings of multiple cases filed in different police stations over protests and rallies linked to PTI.

During the proceedings in the Sangjani case, senior PTI leader Azam Swati appeared before the court, while the remaining accused failed to attend. The court, noting their absence, began the process to declare 60 of them proclaimed offenders and adjourned the matter till October 3.

Separately, in a case lodged at Kohsar police station regarding the October 4 protest, eight out of 82 nominated accused appeared before the court. Among those named in the case are three sisters of the PTI founder. The court summoned the present accused and issued notices for the recall of the absentees.

Meanwhile, during the hearing of the Azadi March case, the court was informed that the Ministry of Law had not yet responded to a letter regarding the PTI founder. The judge adjourned the matter till September 17. — Malik Asad

‘Green SEZs’ success linked to cleaner production methods’

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ISLAMABAD: Green special economic zones (SEZs) in Pakistan will only succeed if cleaner production methods reduce operating costs for firms.

This was stated by Pakistan-China Institute (PCI) Executive Director Mustafa Hyder Sayed at a policy dialogue.

Speaking at the Pakistan-China Green Development Dialogue in Beijing, which coincided with Prime Minister Shahbaz Sharif’s visit to China, Sayed stressed that practical implementation must take precedence over theory.

“Green SEZs will succeed when cleaner production lowers operating costs for firms. That means bankable shared utilities, simple rules for SME participation, and incentives tied to verified performance,” he said.

The dialogue, organised by PCI in collaboration with the School of Environment at Tsinghua University, also marked the launch of a new policy paper titled “From Policy to Practice: Operationalizing Green Special Economic Zones under CPEC via China’s Eco-Industrial Parks Lessons.”

The paper was co-authored by Sayed, Mohammad Umar Farooq, and Professor Tian Jinping. It adapts lessons from China’s eco-industrial parks for Pakistan’s CPEC-linked SEZs, with a focus on standards, shared infrastructure, finance, operations, and data.

Professor Tian of the Tsinghua University, in his remarks, highlighted China’s success with eco-industrial parks, crediting clear standards, shared utilities, and data-driven management. “When parks share treatment plants, steam, and heat-recovery systems, costs fall and compliance improves,” he noted, adding that Pakistan should pilot, measure, and scale projects for results.

Delivering the keynote, Minister of State for Climate Change Dr Shezra Mansab Ali Kharal underlined the importance of adapting China’s experience to Pakistan’s needs. “The green transition does not mean turning all lights off; it means turning better lights on,” she said. Kharal stressed that policy alignment between the federation and provinces was vital to send “one clear signal” to industry.

The dialogue brought together policymakers, researchers, and industry experts to map out a practical roadmap for establishing Green SEZs in Pakistan under the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC). — Staff Reporter

Pakistan's first women's software technology park inaugurated in Muzaffarabad

By Tariq Naqash

MUZAFFARABAD: The Special Communications Organisation (SCO), a public-sector telecom provider in Azad Jammu and Kashmir (AJK) and Gilgit-Baltistan (GB), on Wednesday launched the country's first dedicated Women's Software Technology Park at Fatima Jinnah Women's Postgraduate College in downtown Muzaffarabad.

The facility was inaugurated by SCO Director General Maj-Gen Umar Ahmed Shah at a ceremony attended by AJK Prime Minister's Coordinator Asma Andrabi, Secretary Information Technology Rashid Hanif, Director Public Instruction Colleges Prof Dr Khawaja Abdul Rehman, Muzaffarabad Station Commander Brig Qaiser, SCO Sector Commander Col Yousaf Javed, Principal Huma Mufti and a large number of officials, faculty members and students.

Designed exclusively for women, the park offers a modern, secure and fully equipped workspace for freelancers, IT professionals and entrepreneurs. It aims to generate employment, foster entrepreneurship and build technical capacity, thereby contributing to women's social and economic empowerment.

After the inauguration, Maj-Gen Shah toured various sections of the park, interacted with young freelancers and praised their work.

He also appreciated the state-of-the-art facilities, including uninterrupted electricity, high-speed internet and advanced training infrastructure, which he said would ensure a professional environment for women.

"The establishment of a dedicated technology park for women reflects SCO's Vision 2025, which seeks to enhance women's participation in technology and enable them to play a significant role in Pakistan's growing digital economy," he said.

He noted that under IT Vision 2025, SCO had established 17 software technology parks and 76 freelancing hubs across Azad Kashmir and Gilgit-Baltistan over the past 20 months, creating more than 7,000 jobs and empowering over 1,500 freelancers.

By the end of the current month, he added, the network would be expanded to 100 centres.

The Muzaffarabad park - 8th in AJK - was aimed at bridging the digital divide, encouraging women-led startups and boosting Pakistan's IT exports by showcasing the potential of AJK's youth, he said.

Ms Andrabi congratulated SCO on what she called a "historic achievement" and said the project would always be remembered as a milestone in women's empowerment.

She commended the organisation for providing a dedicated space for women freelancers, recalling that in the past they had faced numerous obstacles in

pursuing IT careers.

"Now, with a safe and culturally secure environment, they have an easy pathway to compete with the international community and prove their talent," she said.

She expressed the hope that AJK's women, particularly students, would use IT positively to move towards self-reliance and generate valuable foreign exchange for their families.

Meanwhile, Col Javed told *Dawn* that the Pakistan Software Export Board (PSEB) had earlier announced plans for a women-exclusive Software Technology Park at Women University Bagh and initially promoted it as the country's first such facility.

However, since that project was still at least two months from completion, "it is SCO that now has the distinction of launching Pakistan's first operational Women's Software Technology Park with today's inauguration in Muzaffarabad," he said.

Nums MDCAT rescheduled for Sept 28

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ISLAMABAD: Considering the difficulties for many candidates due to current torrential rains and floods, National University of Medical Sciences (Nums) has rescheduled Medical and Dental College Admission Test (MDCAT) for the year 2025.

The test, which was earlier announced to be held on Sept 14, will be conducted on September 28 (Sunday).

According to message posted on the website of Nums, decision has been made in order to give equal and fair chance to all the candidates. "Nums stands by the people of Pakistan affected by these rains and floods," it stated.

Nums, being admitting University, will conduct Entry Test for Admission in MBBS/BDS Programme Session 2025-26 in its Constituent, Affiliated and all Military (Armed Forces) Administered Medical and Dental Colleges.

Public sector medical and dental colleges include Army Medical College Rawalpindi and Dental Section Army Medical College Rawalpindi.

Private sector medical and dental colleges include CMH Institute of Medical Sciences Bahawalpur Cantt, CMH Kharian Medical College Kharian Cantt, CMH Lahore Medical College and Institute of Dentistry Lahore Cantt, CMH Multan Institute of Medical Sciences Multan Cantt, HITEC Institute of Medical Sciences Taxila Cantt, Karachi Institute of Medical Sciences Malir Cantt, Quetta Institute of Medical Sciences Quetta Cantt, Wah Medical College Wah Cantt, CIMS Dental College Multan, CMH Lahore Medical College and Institute of Dentistry Lahore Cantt, HITEC Dental College Taxila Cantt and Quetta College of Dentistry. — Staff Reporter

Pakistan, China ink skill-building pacts under CPEC's second phase

Page 4

By Our Staff Reporter

ISLAMABAD: The National Vocational and Technical Training Commission (NAVTTTC) is hopeful that 11 professional and training programmes will be formally signed on Thursday between Pakistan and China under CPEC Phase II.

According to a press release issued here, on the occasion of Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's visit to China, Pakistan and China are set to sign 11 agreements aimed at launching professional training programmes in Pakistan under CPEC's second phase.

The press release stated that the government aims to ensure the earliest completion of

CPEC. In this regard, the PM entrusted the responsibility of preparing a highly skilled workforce for CPEC Phase II to the Federal Minister for Education and Professional Training, Dr Khalid Maqbool Siddiqui. Subsequently, the minister set the targets.

On his instruction, Chairperson of NAVTTTC Gulmina Bilal Ahmed visited China, presented a briefing, and requested Chinese authorities regarding the preparation of professional training programmes in Pakistan with Chinese cooperation under CPEC Phase II.

"As a result, the Chinese side agreed to 11 specialised programmes which will benefit thousands of Pakistanis. These pro-

grammes include: training in the Chinese language along with the preparation of local instructors; initiatives in e-commerce, software technology, drone applications, agriculture, and medical laboratory sciences; development of curricula, digital courses, and degree programmes in modern fields such as intelligent manufacturing; provision of dual diploma and degree programmes offering Pakistani students opportunities to study in China; teacher exchange and training initiatives; establishment of specialised workshops and training centres in nursing, rehabilitation, pharmacy, smart health, non-ferrous metallurgy, and intelligent mining technologies; and interna-

tionally recognised certifications in key fields such as construction engineering, artificial intelligence, agriculture, and hospitality management," the press release read.

It further stated that NAVTTTC and the Government of China also signed 11 Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) related to these projects, under which the formal agreements will be signed on Thursday.

"Officials noted that these projects will not only contribute to preparing thousands of skilled individuals in Pakistan but will also create opportunities for dignified employment both within CPEC-related ventures and in the global job market," the press release added.

Parliament to take up bill to give legal cover to employees regularised during PPP govt

Brief shows move will not have any additional financial impact on national kitty

By Ikram Junaidi

ISLAMABAD: While the parliament may consider a bill in coming weeks to give legal cover to employees regularised by a cabinet subcommittee headed by Syed Khursheed Shah some two decades ago, a brief shows that around 20pc of 5,000 employees regularised in Basic Pay Scale (BPS) 16 and above have already retired.

Moreover, there will be no additional financial impact as all the employees have already been drawing salaries they were entitled to.

As mover, Syed Khursheed Shah is unwell and unable to personally present the bill in parliament, employees have tied their hopes on Raja Pervaiz

Ashraf who may table the bill on Khursheed Shah's behalf.

During the PPP government in 2008-13, the cabinet subcommittee headed by Syed Khursheed Shah was established for the regularisation of daily wage and contract employees. Tens of thousands of employees were regularised in dozens of ministries and divisions. However, the Supreme Court, last year ordered the authorities to restart the process under Federal Public Service Commission (FPSC) as the employees were regularised without tests and interviews. Majority of employees, regularised by the cabinet subcommittee, were non-gazetted, so they did not need to be referred to the FPSC.

According to the data collected by *Dawn*, around 5,000 employees of BPS-16 and above were regularised.

According to the brief, the bill titled: "The Protection of Rights of Regularised Civil Servants and Employees Bill, 2024" has been introduced by Syed Khursheed Shah. It claimed that employees were

regularised by the subcommittee of the Cabinet and notified by the Establishment Division.

It claims that the matter involves no additional financial burden on the exchequer as all employees were regularised against sanctioned posts with allocated budgets and have been serving in the positions they were regularised since then.

"The current directive for these officers to qualify through the FPSC examination for 're-regularisation' presents an insurmountable challenge. Having devoted 15 to 25 years of continuous and dedicated service, many are at an advanced stage of their careers. Notably, nearly 20pc have already retired and are drawing pensions, while over 30pc are above the age of 55. For them, the test and interview requirement is not only impractical but a source of profound anxiety and mental trauma," the brief states.

A doctor of Pakistan Institute of Medical Sciences (Pims), Dr Saifur Rehman, said during the PPP government (2008-2013), the then prime minister, Syed Yousaf Raza Gilani, constituted

a subcommittee, which regularised thousands of employees, and the Ministry of Finance allocated the required budget sanctioned for each post during 2011 to 2025.

"However, after 16 years, the government is now seeking to send these employees home, directing that all officers from BPS-16 and above must once again qualify through the FPSC examination for their regularisation. At this stage of life, after having served most of their careers it is extremely difficult, if not impossible, for them to undergo this process again," he said.

"To address this serious issue, Syed Khursheed Shah has submitted a Private Member's Bill to give legal cover to employees regularised between 2008 and 2012, just as all provincial assemblies have already secured similar protections for their employees. The Cabinet Committee has also recommended that the bill may be laid before the National Assembly. However, the federal government appears reluctant to pass it, which could render thou-

sands of senior officers — who have served diligently for decades — jobless," Dr Saif claimed.

"Thousands of affected employees, including senior doctors, professors, teachers and staff serving in federal ministries, are under immense stress and depression," Dr Saif revealed.

Prominent orthopaedic surgeon at Pims Dr Asfandiyar Khan, while talking to *Dawn*, urged the parliamentarians to play their role so that the bill regarding protection of employees sails through the parliament.

In September 2024, some employees approached the Supreme Court for seniority and other benefits, but the apex court ordered them to be sent to the FPSC.

On March 9, 2025, the Establishment Division issued an order under which all ministries and divisions started working to send regularised employees to FPSC. Now the passage of the bill through parliament can remove the looming sword on permanent basis.

Govt ready to hold talks with opposition on Mines Act: Bugti

Page 5

By Saleem Shahid

QUETTA: Balochistan Chief Minister Sarfraz Bugti has said the government is ready to hold talks with opposition parties on the Mines and Mineral Act approved by the provincial assembly, but challenged by some political parties in the court.

The act has been challenged in the Balochistan High Court by several former leaders, political parties, and lawyers who argue it violates the rights of the people of Balochistan and undermines the province's control over its natural resources.

The constitutional petitions contend that the act was passed without proper consultation and centralises control over mineral resources, potentially leading to the displacement of locals. The court is jointly hearing all petitions and has issued notices to the federal and provincial governments.

Speaking on the floor of the house during the Balochistan Assembly session, the chief minister said that when the Mines and Mineral Act was introduced in the house "we tried to develop consensus on the issue and succeeded in achieving that".

However, he said, some political parties, including those having no representation in the parliament, have challenged the act in the court. "I talked to leaders political parties and told them the government is ready to hold talks to resolve the issue through talks instead of taking the matter to the court.

"It is an issue of the parliament and it should be resolved in the parliament through dialogue instead of it being decided at some other place," Mr Bugti said, adding that "if someone wants to form a committee on it, we are ready as the issue could be resolved through dialogue and joint efforts".

"Political parties who approached the court of law should come with their suggestions and sit with officials of the mines and minerals department and representatives of the government to discuss and improve the act," Mr Bugti said, adding that by removing objections on the act, "we can get the act approved with consensus in the house".

Opposition leader in the Assembly Mir Younis Aziz Zehri welcomed the offer and said he would talk to leaders of opposition parties on the offer of Mr Bugti.

Speaking on the issue in the house, Minister for Mines and Mineral Mir Shoaib Noshervani said he has sent suggestions of Mines and Mineral Association representatives on the issue to the chief minister.

Toll from BNP March rally blast rises

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activities". On the other hand, Balochistan Chief Minister Mir Sarfraz Bugti vowed to bring the perpetrators of the deadly bombing near Shahwani Stadium to justice, declaring that terrorists would not be allowed to destabilize the province's peace.

While addressing a press conference, Additional Chief Secretary (Home) Hamza Shafqaat confirmed that the suicide attack took place on Sariab Road some 500 metres away from the venue of the BNP public meeting and about 45 minutes after it ended.

"If the explosion had taken place inside the rally grounds, the loss of life would have been far greater," he noted.

Mr Shafqaat said 120 police personnel were deployed at the rally for security. "The incident was beyond control and could not have been prevented, but identifying those behind the blast is our responsibility," he said.

He said that the remains of the suicide bomber were recovered from the site, where he detonated himself. The attacker, believed to be under 30 years, used around 8kg explosives for the blast that also claimed the life of two policemen. The additional chief secretary announced that in light of persistent threat alerts, no rallies or gatherings would be permitted after Maghrib prayers.

He said security threats were expected to remain high on Sept 6, appealing to the public to limit unnecessary movement on Defence Day. He said security would also be tightened for the upcoming 12th Rabi-ul-Awwal programmes and urged political parties and the public to cooperate with law enforcement agencies. He said CM Bugti had announced a compensation package of Rs1.5 million for the families of those martyred, along with Rs500,000 in medical support for each of the injured.

Condemnations

PM Shehbaz Sharif also telephoned Balochistan CM Sarfraz Bugti to express deep sorrow over the tragic blast. The prime minister strongly condemned the blast and conveyed deep grief over the



MEN console each other at a hospital after the death of their relative in a bomb blast at a public rally in Quetta.—Reuters

loss of precious lives in the blast. He also prayed for the speedy recovery of the injured.

He said the attack on the political rally was clear evidence of the nefarious conspiracy by terrorists to spread chaos in Balochistan.

Meanwhile, leaders of Tehreek-i-Tahaffuz Ayeen-i-Pakistan (TTAP), an alliance of opposition parties, condemned the explosion and alleged that it was an attempt to pressurise the political movement. TTAP Secretary General Asad Qaiser, who was flanked by Barrister Salman Akram Raja, Raja Nasir Abbas, Muhammad Zubair, Mustafa Nawaz Khokhar and others, in a statement reminded the plotters to think again, warning that there would be dire consequences. Pakistan cannot be made an Egypt of General Sisi and world has seen so many Idi Amin(s), Barrister Akram said.

In Turbat, National Party President and former chief minister Dr Abdul Malik Baloch addressing a press conference condemned the suicide attack on a BNP rally in Quetta, calling it a "well-planned conspiracy" to curb political activity and corner democratic forces.

Senate Deputy Chairman Syedal Khan Nasar also condemned the "cowardly act of terrorism," offering condolences to the bereaved families and solidarity with BNP President Sardar Akhtar Mengal.

Security meeting

Earlier, the chief minister presided over a security meeting,

attended by Balochistan Chief Secretary Shakeel Qadir Khan, Mr Shafqaat, Principal Secretary Babar Khan, Balochistan Levies Director General Ghaffar Magasi and acting IGP Saeed Wazir, Quetta Commissioner Shahzaib Kakar, and other senior officials.

CM Bugti warned the officials that there would be zero tolerance for lapses in public protection, highlighting the need to strengthen security protocols. He directed the additional chief secretary to keep both the public and media informed with "verified updates" to counter misinformation. "The terrorists behind the Shahwani Stadium blast will be brought to their logical conclusion and held accountable under the law," he said.

He ordered that critically injured individuals would be transferred to Karachi through government air services, if necessary, to ensure optimal medical care.

The chief minister urged political parties and citizens to cooperate with law enforcement agencies during the current threat alert. "This is a time for unity and collective resolve to defeat those who seek to spread fear," he said.

In preparation for upcoming religious events, Bugti instructed officials to devise a comprehensive security plan for the 12th of Rabi' al-Awwal processions. He appealed to the public to support authorities in maintaining peace during these gatherings.

Behram Baloch in Gwadar and Ikram Junaidi in Islamabad also contributed to this report

US lawmakers briefed on flood devastation in Pakistan

Pakistani Americans highlight urgent need for food, clean water, medical aid and rehabilitation for millions hit by floods

By Anwar Iqbal

WASHINGTON: The Pakistani American community has launched a campaign to support victims of the 2025 floods, briefing US lawmakers on Capitol Hill on Tuesday about the scale of the disaster and urging international engagement.

The US-based Muslim Charity Helping Hand for Relief and Development (HHRD), largely run by Pakistani Americans, spent the day on Capitol Hill, highlighting the urgent need for food, clean water, medical assistance, and long-term rehabilitation for millions of people affected by the floods. Pakistan's Ambassador to the United States, Rizwan Saeed Sheikh, described the floods as "an unprecedented disaster that has set back economic growth, and continues to cause devastation across the country".

Warning that next year's monsoon could arrive earlier and bring even greater devastation, he called Pakistan "a frontline state" in the fight against climate change.

"Governments will do what they can, but all should come forward and help. The world must form a collective strategy to deal with recurring disasters," he said.

The HHRD also announced dedicating an initial \$5 million for relief and rehabilitation work and pledged to expand its efforts. The

Pakistani community is holding fundraising events across the United States and Canada to supplement the relief efforts.

HHRD officials told lawmakers that the floods have directly affected more than five million people, with over 20 million at risk, underscoring the urgency of global support. Since late June, torrential rains and flash floods have battered Pakistan, especially Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Gilgit-Baltistan.

The floods have killed 881 people, injured more than 1,100, destroyed 11,000 homes, and damaged 250 bridges and 415 miles of roads. Some 1.2 million hectares have been submerged, including 853,000 hectares of cropland.

A UN report, released on Wednesday, warned that "the situation remains highly fluid, with reservoirs at full capacity and heavy rainfall forecast in early September, cautioning that new surges along the Chenab and other rivers could impact downstream districts in South Punjab".

HHRD officials said their teams have been providing mobile clinics, water filtration systems, search-and-rescue operations, cooked meals, hygiene kits, mosquito nets, milk, and "Smile Boxes" for children. By early September, their relief teams had reached over 62,000 people across 13 districts, including Lahore, Sialkot, Swat, Neelum Valley, and Gilgit-Baltistan.

Officials emphasised that this initial \$5m is a starting point and that the organisation intends to expand its reach in the coming weeks and months.

Ambassador Sheikh also highlighted the proactive spirit of Pakistanis, noting that citizens often take initiative in disaster response without waiting for government intervention.

Why breaching is ‘not an option’ for Sindh

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medium and high flood through the Guddu and Sukkur barrages in July and August of this season.

How much water will pass through Guddu now remains a guessing game, considering flow patterns at the barrage. The barrage passed a peak of 550,965 cusecs on Sept 1 — recorded at Trimmu first — from Punjab.

Officials remain unsure whether floodwaters from the Chenab would precede combined flows from the Ravi and Sutlej, which would accumulate at Panjnad before heading to Guddu.

With a discharge capacity of 865,000 cusecs against Trimmu’s 875,000, Panjnad is the second last destination before the tributaries merge into the mighty Indus.

Sindh Irrigation Minister Jam Khan Shoro, who is stationed at the Sukkur Barrage to monitor floods,

told Dawn that breaches were not an option.

“There is no option of breach in our minds,” he said, adding that Sindh’s topography tells a different story when it comes to such decisions.

“Gradient in Sindh’s lands is lower than the Indus River,” he argued, while asking people not to worry about any possible breaches. “I tell those putting this query that we can’t breach a dyke. It’s not an option,” he assured.

Peculiar gradient

Explaining this phenomenon, Tando Jam Sindh Agriculture University (SAU) Vice Chancellor Prof Dr Altaf Siyal said there were variables in the soil gradient in Punjab and Sindh and breaching a dyke was a different story for each province.

“A breach can be made on either side of the Indus. If it occurs on the

right bank, the water will head westward because those pockets have large depressions. In case of a breach on the left bank, it will impact the Nara canal of Sukkur Barrage first before heading downstream,” Dr Siyal said.

A breach around Khairpur Mirs and Naushahro Feroze would send water to the river from the Qazi Ahmed side on the left bank of the Indus.

According to him, any breach on the right bank upstream of Sukkur will send water down to Manchhar Lake via the Right Bank Outfall Drain (RBOD)/Main Nara Valley Drain (MNVD).

“Manchhar Lake then allows the authorities to redirect water to the Indus if the river flows remain on the lower side,” he said, alluding to the 2010 super floods.

In 2010, a massive breach 60km downstream of Guddu displaced millions after the Tori Bund devel-

oped a fissure, affecting seven districts on the right bank. The water eventually ended up in the lake.

In 2022 too, heavy rainfall in the Kirthar Range inundated parts of the right bank districts, including Qambar-Shahdadkot, Larkana, Dadu, and Jamshoro. These flows entered the Indus after Manchhar had to be breached the same month at two locations.

A high-powered judicial commission was formed to probe the causes of the 2010 flood breaches at Tori and Molchand-Surjani at Kot Almo in Thatta, downstream of Kotri Barrage, on Aug 27, 2010.

The report mentioned that around 1.47MAF water was released from Tori and 70pc of the 150km on Begari Sindh Feeder, an off-taking channel of Guddu Barrage on its right side was destroyed.

The chief engineer of the Guddu barrage and his team, along with the irrigation secretary, were held

responsible for negligence.

Discharges in Punjab

Mr Jam and Irrigation Secretary Zarif Khoro also shared information about discharges recorded in Punjab, especially at Trimmu, Panjnad, Head Sidhnai over Ravi (with 157,580 cusecs discharge at 4pm Wednesday) and Sulemanki over Sutlej (122,736 cusecs). Chenab, in fact, passed a peak of 1,077,951 cusecs in the last week of August, which Sindh is now waiting for.

“Let’s see which peak reaches Guddu first. My hunch is that the time lag between barrages has increased,” he said.

Sutlej and Ravi are passing their peaks, too, and the water will head for Guddu while Indus water from Taunsa will also reach the first barrage in Sindh, adding to these discharges. Panjnad’s downstream flow was 217,447 cusecs at 6pm on

Wednesday. These are the flows released from the Tarbela Dam built on the Indus.

Even the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) mentioned that 1.3m cusecs of water would reach Guddu Barrage, which has a capacity of 1.2m cusecs.

The irrigation secretary said that losses between the two reaches of the barrages needed to be factored in as well.

He also drew a parallel between this year and 2014’s Chenab flows. “A discharge of 947,000 cusecs downstream Khanki [over Chenab] on Sept 7 eventually turned out to be a flow of 453,570 cusecs at Panjnad on Sept 16 and 475,000 cusecs [inclusive of Indus flows] at Guddu on Sept 19.

He, however, assured that the government was prepared to deal with any situation involving a flow of 900,000 cusecs, considered a super flood.

IHC adopts new rules by razor-thin majority

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litigants and lawyers.

The judges observed that instead of referring the matter directly to the National Accountability Bureau or the Federal Investigation Agency, the federal government should be asked to carry out a comprehensive probe and take corrective measures.

CJ's powers

Unlike these two agenda items, the proposed IHC Rules, 2025 triggered a sharp division among the judges. While the chief justice strongly supported them, senior judges, including Justice Kayani, Justice Jahangiri, Justice Sattar, Justice Sardar Ejaz, and Justice Imtiaz, opposed their adoption and urged amendments.

A day before the meeting, Justice Sattar and

Justice Sardar Ejaz Ishaq Khan had written letters to their colleagues, voicing serious concerns that administrative powers were being misused to sideline dissenting judges.

Both judges strongly objected to a new circular requiring judges to obtain a No-Objection Certificate (NOC) from the chief justice for foreign travel.

They alleged that case assignments were being manipulated to benefit judges transferred to the IHC alongside the chief justice, while permanent judges who had opposed his transfer were being sidelined.

The letters also challenged the chief justice's use of the "master of the roster" power to transfer part-heard cases.

Justice Khan also took exception to the new Practice and Procedure

Rules (PPR), reminding his colleagues that PPR had already been gazetted without approval or even proper discussion by the full bench.

He noted the voluminous document, spanning more than 600 pages, had been provided only a day and a half before the meeting, reducing consultation to a mere formality and making meaningful input impossible.

Justice Khan demanded that five additional agenda items, including these objections, be formally taken up for "proper deliberations" in the full court meeting, signalling his refusal to let the controversy be ignored.

Voting and objections

According to sources, Chief Justice Dogar rejected any alteration in the agenda and pro-

ceeded to call a vote.

Six judges, including the chief justice, approved the rules, while five opposed them and resolved to record their objections in writing.

During the proceedings, the dissenting

judges questioned whether those voting in favour had even read the new rules. The response, sources claimed, was negative.

Some judges, noting the massive length of the document, requested the chief justice to postpone

the meeting, but their plea was turned down. Ultimately, the High Court Establishment (Appointment and Conditions of Service) Rules, 2025 were adopted by a razor-thin majority, leaving the full court deeply divided.

Kalabagh again

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KP Chief Minister Ali Amin Gandapur's support for the dead Kalabagh dam project has stirred up a storm. His endorsement of the dam runs contrary to popular public opinion not just in Sindh and Balochistan but also in his own province. Ostensibly contingent on addressing provincial reservations to the controversial hydropower project on the Indus, his support for the dam — opposed by the provincial assemblies of Sindh, KP and Balochistan in the not so distant past — has baffled his own party as well. PTI leaders from KP and Sindh quickly disowned his statements. Asad Qaiser said that Mr Gandapur's statement did not reflect the party's policy. "The party has always made it clear that there should not be any controversial project. At the moment, there is a need to strengthen the federation," he said. Haleem Adil Sheikh called the proposal a "dead horse", which the PTI never supported. The PPP, through Nisar Khuhro, reminded Mr Gandapur that three provinces had already closed the door on Kalabagh.

The irony, however, is that the PML-N's government in Punjab — often viewed by other federating units as the force behind the project — found itself in rare agreement with Mr Gandapur, with its information minister rushing to countersign the CM's reckless grandstanding on behalf of her party. It exposes deep provincial fault lines: what is seen as a necessity in Punjab is viewed as a sell-out by the other provinces. Mr Gandapur's support for the Kalabagh dam comes on the heels of a plea from Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, during a recent visit to flood-hit Narowal district, for a consensus on new water reservoirs to fight the challenges of climate change and deal with the recurring floods. While the move to bring up Kalabagh dam again risks opening old wounds, the cry for new reservoirs underpins how deeply our power elites are stuck in old, redundant concepts. As if we needed it, the effort to revive a defunct project is proof that our rulers are not capable of thinking beyond brick-and-mortar solutions to our worsening climate challenges. Is this because of lack of imagination or due to the massive money involved in such schemes, or both?

Pakistan, which is among the top 10 countries most vulnerable to the impact of climate change, desperately needs solutions to its problems of water shortages and droughts, devastating floods, erosion of the Indus delta, which is displacing local communities, and so on. These issues cannot be resolved by stopping the river flows through dams. At a time when Pakistan needs unity more than ever, with floods wreaking devastation in several parts of the country and an economy on the brink, it is crucial that our rulers started to think beyond brick-and-mortar structures — if, indeed, they want to solve our increasing climate-related challenges.

A new threat

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THE deadly suicide bombing targeting a BNP-M meeting in Quetta on Tuesday has exposed a lethal new actor involved in Balochistan's violence: the presence of the self-styled Islamic State group in the province, which reportedly claimed the attack. This further complicates a situation where Baloch separatists and to a lesser degree, the TTP, are already involved in acts of terrorism. At least 15 people were confirmed dead in the attack, while BNP-M head Akhtar Mengal, PkMAP leader Mehmood Achakzai and other political leaders remained unhurt. It is shocking that a suicide bomber was able to carry out the atrocity at the site of a mass meeting where the province's leading political figures were gathered. As per the authorities, reports were circulating that terrorists would target the meeting. Mr Mengal and his party were also targeted earlier this year when they were taking out a rally in Mastung in March. Balochistan has witnessed widespread militant violence this year, with major attacks including the Jaffar Express ambush in March and the Khuzdar school bus bombing in May. Security forces have also been targeted in numerous incidents; the latest attack occurred on Tuesday when five security men were martyred in an IED blast in Kech.

These facts, particularly the emergence of IS as a 'player' in Balochistan's milieu of militancy, indicate that a fresh security strategy for the province is required to deal with separatist violence as well as religiously inspired violent actors. In this context, civilian events — political, religious etc — should be given the same security cover as military ones. Observers say there is a threat to upcoming Rabiul Awwal celebrations in the province, therefore the state must redouble its efforts to provide security to these events. Yet in the long run, as this paper has previously argued, a militarised approach to security in Balochistan alone will not produce lasting results. While violent elements must be neutralised, particularly IS and the TTP, and their supporters — internal and external — exposed, these operations must be complemented by facilitating the political process in the province, so that credible political forces, with roots in the masses, can contribute to peace by helping quell the separatist insurgency. Where the involvement of IS is concerned, this fresh threat must be nipped in the bud before it mutates into a monster.

Unkept promises

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GERMANY'S announcement that it is considering the cases of Afghans deported from Pakistan is a welcome gesture at a time when many nations have chosen to turn their backs on those they once pledged to protect. Chancellor Friedrich Merz has said that commitments made by previous German governments will be honoured — a stance that deserves recognition, even if it has come late. After the Afghan Taliban retook Kabul in August 2021, several Western countries — including the US, UK, Canada, Germany and Australia — launched programmes to resettle Afghans who had assisted their missions or who faced grave risks, such as journalists, lawyers, judges and human rights defenders. Tens of thousands left their homes in desperation, some arriving in Pakistan, trusting they would soon be relocated. Many have, instead, found themselves in limbo for years, stranded by slow bureaucracies, shifting immigration policies and waning political will in host countries. Pakistan, which has hosted Afghans for decades despite its own economic and security strains, recently began deporting thousands of undocumented Afghans, including those who had been waiting for visas to Western countries. This has placed people directly back in harm's way. The Taliban view them as traitors. Reprisals can mean arbitrary detention, abduction, torture or death. For women professionals and rights activists, the danger is even greater, as their very visibility makes them targets.

Germany at least appears willing to honour its word. But others have faltered: Britain's resettlement schemes remain paralysed by delays and legal wrangling; Canada has struggled to meet its intake pledges, citing logistical hurdles; and the US still faces a vast backlog of unprocessed special visas. There is no question of the moral responsibility these countries have. To abandon them now is to condemn them to persecution and rob Afghanistan of a better future. These people cannot afford more inaction. Their very survival is at stake.



Governing AI

The policy does not take into account the dynamic nature of AI and technology.

PAKISTAN'S National Artificial Intelligence Policy, 2025, was approved by the federal cabinet on July 31, 2025, as a six-pillar roadmap to build an AI ecosystem. This is a welcome step considering the increasing use, application, availability and risks of AI in technology-related sectors, as well as the increased societal use of it. Whereas the policy outlines an ambitious plan related to AI in Pakistan, it can benefit with several additions, and the addressing of contextual realities including impact and risks that the plan does not acknowledge.

The AI policy created a National AI Fund (allocating 30 per cent of Ignite's Research and Development fund), Centres of Excellence, an AI Council/Directorate, regulatory sandboxes and national compute/data infrastructure. The policy prioritises sector pilots in health, education, agriculture and governance, plus public awareness. Targets include training up to one million professionals by 2030; 3,000 scholarships annually, paid internships and alignment with global standards on ethics, cybersecurity and data protection. Implementation will follow a master plan and action matrix overseen by the Ministry of Information Technology and Telecom.

The policymaking process was not inclusive, as a multi-stakeholder dialogue has not included cross-cutting segments of society, including environmentalists, civil society, digital rights experts, media and the healthcare and education sectors; and there is no transparency around the stakeholder engagement process. Significantly, there is no legislative basis for taking these decisions, as no parliamentary debate (including in the IT committees) has taken place, other than the IT ministry formulating the policy through a nontransparent process.

For starters, the policy does not acknowledge the limitations in Pakistan's digital infrastructure, including a jarring digital divide, which will impact the implementation of the AI policy equitably. For instance, there was a three-week mobile internet shutdown across Balochistan last month, and internet connectivity remains limited in several other parts of the country, including KP's western districts. The policy speaks of including AI in public school curricula, but thousands of

schools across the country are devoid of functional computer labs. For instance, according to reports, 1,482 government-run schools in KP lack computer lab facilities. How then can AI be taught to students who do not even have access to computers? Furthermore, the policy does not take into account the dynamic nature of AI and technology, and outlines no strategy on how curricula for AI in the education sector will be updated with changes in technology, something that may render earlier curricula obsolete.

Whereas the policy mentions use of AI for the environment, it completely ignores the climate-related risks of AI data centres in Pakistan, which, besides being a water-scarce country is acutely vulnerable to the impact of climate change. A large data centre for AI can require up to 5m gallons of water per day — this is the daily amount needed for a town of around 50,000 people. As Pakistan is one of the most water-stressed countries in the world, over 80pc of its population faces water scarcity. Therefore, any AI policy with proposals for local data centres should include a mandatory environmental impact assessment condition.

The AI policy includes plans for E-khidmat centres for public services, health, education, sanitation, energy, security and other government services through AI chatbots, smart reporting and centralised service delivery. This raises surveillance risks, especially in the face of the absence of a data protection regime. Further, overreliance on AI when people need assistance and interface with government officials will only mirror current portals and helplines where people never hear back.

There are significant rights implications of this policy, in particular relating to privacy rights and freedom of speech impacts. It is alarming that the policy has been formulated in the absence of a data protection regime in Pakistan as the Personal Data Protection Bill is yet to be passed; however, the AI policy refers to aspects of the bill despite the status of the law remaining unclear. If a strong data protection regime does not exist, it raises serious concern around privacy risks around the large language models that fuel AI systems.

Furthermore, the policy details how an AI directorate will be formed to provide regulatory

guidelines to address “disinformation, data breaches and fake news”. It is necessary that such steps entail a robust and inclusive parliamentary process, as such language raises alarms related to freedom of expression. The policy does not mention the Prevention of Electronic Crimes Act, 2016, which deals with issues such as disinformation and ‘fake news’ in its amended form as of February 2025, and the overlap that the work of this directorate may have with that of the Social Media Regulatory Authority that the Peca amendments proposed.

The Digital Rights Foundation in its analysis of the policy stresses the “serious questions around transparency, ethical safeguards and protecting marginalised communities from discrimination”, which is imperative considering the risks of discrimination that automated systems in AI pose. In the absence of provisions in the policy on human rights risk assessments, the human rights impact of AI systems in the country are likely to create new issues rather than address existing ones.

Relatedly, the policy includes proposals for special training programmes for women and persons with disabilities, but it does not address the expanded role AI is playing in technology-facilitated gender-based violence. At an event on TFGBV, a Pakistani man noted that “previously men would throw acid at women to destroy their lives, but now men have to create an AI-generated video to destroy the life of a woman”. This shows the gendered risk that AI poses to Pakistani women and gender minorities in particular, and it should be reflected in the policy.

Lastly, whereas the AI policy addresses expanding AI systems in Pakistan and supporting innovation and education related to it, there need to be specific provisions around developing machine-learning models in languages most common in Pakistan so that reliance on foreign languages reduces and inclusive expansion of AI tools are available to speakers and readers of Urdu, Sindhi, Punjabi, Pashto, Seraiki, Balochi languages. ■

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Extracting dollars

YOU have no doubt heard of 'overheating', the word used in economic language to describe an economy that is growing, but at the same time, seeing rising inflation. This combination of growth with inflation portends trouble because it is a sign that the economy is trying to serve levels of demand that its productive apparatus is not capable of meeting.

Over-extraction is something similar, but on the opposite end of the spectrum. This is when a state tries to extract for itself resources from an economy that the productive apparatus is not able to supply. And that is where we have reached in Pakistan. We are now in a situation where the state is trying to extract dollars and revenues from an economy in quantities that the productive apparatus cannot supply.

Consider the state's growing appetite for dollars. One data series illuminates this. Look at the net foreign assets, or NFAs, in the State Bank's monetary data series. This data measures the total foreign currency liquidity in the system. You'll notice three entries. One tells you how much of the NFA is held by the State Bank. The second tells you how much is held by commercial banks. And the third entry is the total.

Notice that total NFAs are negative for a long time. Start from July 2023, when they are negative Rs1.7 trillion, and notice how the line moves in one long, slow, agonising upward trajectory, pock-marked with dips along the way, until it finally breaks into positive territory on the last day of March 2025. This long, slow, agonising climb out of negative territory is one of the two key elements of what they call 'stabilisation', because so long as NFAs are negative, it means the foreign currency liabilities on the system are larger than the assets.

It took years for this figure to break out above the x-axis of the graph, and the journey was marked with strong devaluation of the rupee, strangulation of imports, sharp curbs on cross-border payments, administrative measures on land border crossings, threats and cajoling for money changers and incentives for banks to rake in more remittances through formal channels. In

short, it took nearly the full might of the state and central bank, for well over 20 months, to pull this line up from its low point back then to positive territory today.

Now look at the series for NFAs held by the State Bank. Notice how it breaks out above zero back in August 2024 and keeps rising from that point, suffering a few setbacks along the way in late December and early January. By June 2025, it hits a peak of Rs657 billion. Not bad considering its journey began from negative Rs883bn back in June 2023, on the eve of the stabilisation programme. That's an increase of Rs1.5tr.

The state is trying to
extract more revenues,
and more dollars from an
economy that is not able
to supply these.

Notice how in June this figure drops suddenly back into negative territory, then leaps out of it the next week to a new peak of Rs968bn. This is a sudden outflow due to repayment of a Chinese bond, followed by an equally sudden inflow due to a rollover, so the same liquidity flows out of the system with the repayment and back in again once the rollover is finalised from the Chinese side.

Then look at what happens after that. State Bank NFAs rise massively to Rs1.45tr, and remain stable more or less at the level till today. Meanwhile, NFAs held by private banks plunge, falling from negative Rs353bn when the rollover happens to negative Rs741bn today.

Once plotted on a graph, these three lines will tell a stark story of how all the foreign exchange that flowed into the country once the current account was stabilised with great pain and sacrifice somewhere in the early months of 2023 was

then bought and stashed away by the central bank in order to build its reserves. And this frenzied buying is being carried out at a price dictated by the government. The fact that NFAs of scheduled banks remain negative through all this entire period as the State Bank's assets rise to levels not seen for years tells us that the state is basically taking all the foreign exchange flowing into the country for itself. And the data shows that this process is intensifying from May 2025 onwards.

This helps explain the rising pressures on the exchange rate in these months. It also helps explain why maybe exporters are holding back export proceeds in anticipation of a potential exchange rate devaluation. It also helps us understand why money changers were called in one more time a few weeks ago and told to stop trying to sell their dollars in the black market. It helps us understand why the State Bank is not cutting interest rates even though inflation has fallen to historic lows. It also helps explain the large spread between the price of the dollar in the interbank market versus the hundi or hawala market, which probably reflects the true price more accurately.

We hit peak stabilisation somewhere in the early months of 2025. From there, we have now moved into over-extraction mode. The state is trying to extract more revenues, and more dollars from an economy that is not able to supply these. At least not as presently constituted. So the state resorts to heightened coercive measures, which is what gives the whole enterprise the look of extraction. This is no longer the pursuit of macroeconomic stability that we are in. This is now a state bleeding its own economy to feed its appetites.

The balance-of-payments crisis that Pakistan faced in the summer of 2022 is what happens when you gun an overheating economy to grow harder and faster. The present juncture is what you get when you try to extract dollars and revenues from a stagnant economy. We have gone from overheating to over-extraction. And the only way out is to either reform, or find an external bailout. ■

The writer is a business and economy journalist.



True South

THE years ahead are shorter than those already lived. Time therefore to honour two Pakistanis lost to history: Ch. M. Zafrulla Khan (1893-1985) and Eqbal Ahmad (1933-1999). Both shared a deep affinity with the Palestinians and fought, albeit armless, for their cause. Like the Arabist T.E. Lawrence, they too wrote their "will across the sky in stars".

Chaudhry Zafrulla served as our first foreign minister, and then as president of both the UN General Assembly and the International Court of Justice.

In November 1947, Ch. Zafrulla addressed the UN General Assembly in New York on the plan to divide Palestine. He spoke scathingly of the inequity of a proposed arrangement under which Jews who constituted 33 per cent of the population received 60pc of the area of Palestine. Of the irrigated, cultivable areas, 84pc would go to the new Jewish state and only 16pc to the Arabs.

Despite Ch. Zafrulla's persuasive rhetoric, the state of Israel came into being on May 14, 1948. The US recognised it the same day.

In Eqbal Ahmad's case, conflict birthed his pacifism. Wounded during the Kashmir conflict in 1948, he later participated in the revolution in Algeria that led to that nation's independence from France in 1962. The US involvement in Vietnam agitated him and because he had the support of like-minded thinkers, the US administration longed to get rid of this 'troublesome' intellectual.

In 1971, the FBI arrested him on the implausible charge that he, as part of the Harrisburg Seven, planned to abduct Dr Henry Kissinger (then national security adviser to Richard Nixon). After a ridiculously long trial, he and his fellow accused were acquitted. In his later years, like a moth attracted to a flame, Eqbal returned to the US where he became a respected if isolated academic.

His riposte in 1968 to Samuel Huntington (of *The Clash of Civilisations* fame) deserves to be recalled. Ahmad identified the perceptible gap between Third World countries' impatience for change and America's obsession with order, their longing for national sovereignty and America's preference for pliable allies, and their desire to see their soil free of occupation and America's need for military bases abroad.

Both Ch. Zafrulla and Eqbal Ahmad have become prisoners of their own reputations. The ideals they espoused and their voices of reason have since been relegated to oblivion. Mercifully, they have not lived to see Prime Minister Netanyahu flout the authority of the International Criminal Court after it issued his arrest warrants for war crimes and crimes against humanity. So far, Netanyahu has escaped arrest and punish-

ment. The Nazis at Nuremberg couldn't. Nor have they lived to see President Donald Trump (like some flaxen-haired Samson) pull down the numerous pillars of order that define civilisation, on himself and on us.

The parallel between the Israeli/Palestinian conflict and the ongoing Indo-Pak impasse sprang to mind, after reading the Israeli expert M. Horowitz's book *Hope and Despair*, subtitled *Israel's Future in the New Middle East* (2024). Horowitz argues that Israel faces two choices — continuing confrontation which would lead to partial isolation, or engagement with the enemy. Former PM Yitzhak Rabin pursued the latter. As he put it, "You don't make peace with friends; you can only make peace with your enemies". Rabin paid for this belief with his life.

Almost 30 years ago, in 1996, Eqbal Ahmad spoke of the armed minorities in Egypt, Jordan, Saudi Arabia — "armed minorities ruling majorities" — and predicted that "they are going to collaborate with the United States and wherever necessary with Israel

at any cost". (The Abraham Accords of 2020 are the first step.)

The recent SCO conclave in Tianjin is the modern equivalent of the Yalta Conference of 1945. At Yalta, the Big Three

The ideals espoused by two Pakistanis have been relegated to oblivion.

nations — the US, Great Britain and the Soviet Union — carved the world into dominions of influence. Then, China and India did not matter. At Tianjin last week, China hosted 24 countries representing 43 per cent of the world's population. The US and Israel could only watch with dismay as China, Russia and India came together to draw the contours of a new global order. (Significantly, the official languages used at Tianjin were Chinese and Russian, not English and French.)

An invisible presence at Tianjin was the late Chairman Mao Zedong. In his famous *Red Book of Quotations* (1966), he anticipated Trumpism: "The people of all the continents should unite, all peace-loving countries should unite, and all countries subjected to US aggression, control, intervention or bullying [emphasis mine] should unite". In 1945, the Big Three thought they had triangulated the world. In 2025, a multipolar world has decided that the US, the EU and Nato should not matter. Their True North is being replaced by a Global South. ■

New monsoon reality

IN the mountains of South Asia, the monsoon once arrived like a marching band — broad, rhythmic and predictable. Today, however, it strikes with precision, dropping torrents of water on narrow valleys and towns while nearby areas stay dry. These ultra-intense downpours, commonly called ‘cloudbursts’, unleash more than 100mm of rain per hour over small catchments, turning a single street or hamlet into ground zero of destruction.

In August 2025, Buner in KP experienced such a storm: 150mm of rain fell in just an hour, unleashing flash floods and landslides that killed hundreds. Across the border, India’s Uttarkashi saw a cloudburst sweep away homes in Dharali, while another struck Kishtwar, displacing families and flattening infrastructure. These are not isolated accidents but part of a wider transformation of the South Asian monsoon, which is becoming less predictable and more violent.

The science is clear. Warmer air traps and carries more moisture, and as mountains force this moisture upward, it condenses and falls violently, creating what scientists describe as ‘rain bombs’. The IPCC confirms that heavy precipitation events are becoming more frequent across South Asia and will continue intensifying throughout this century. When such rain bombs coincide with glacier-melt season, the impact multiplies: river flows spike suddenly, flash flood risks surge and downstream communities face devastation.

The toll of these storms is profound. Houses, bridges, micro-hydel, orchards and entire markets can vanish in minutes, leaving settlements cut off from roads, power and communication. Pakistan’s catastrophic 2022 floods caused nearly \$30 billion in damage, demonstrating how even localised cloudbursts can tip fragile mountain economies into long-term crisis. Environmentally, saturated slopes collapse, boulders crash downstream, river channels shift, forests are uprooted and vital water sources become contaminated, deepening health and food insecurity.

Urgent action is therefore non-negotiable. The KP government must rigorously enforce the River Protection Ordinance of 2002, which prohibits construction within 200 feet (61 metres) of riverbanks and restricts development up to 1,500m in sensitive mountain zones. Recent ADB modelling for the Swat River basin reconfirmed that these buffers are not mere regulations but essential safeguards. Authorities must also densify rain-gauge networks, integrate radar with AI-based nowcasting, restrict construction on debris-flow fans and dry streambeds, and operationalise monsoon contingency

plans with clear responsibilities. Investments should prioritise resilient infrastructure — larger culverts, debris racks, raised platforms and single-span bridges that can survive turbulent flows. Equally important is facilitating rapid access to international loss and damage finance, so recovery is swift and communities do not sink deeper into poverty.

Preparedness at the household and community level is equally critical. Families should map hazards such as unstable slopes and blocked gullies and keep go-bags ready with IDs, medicine, torches, power banks, dry rations and water purification tablets. Villages can link meteorological alerts to WhatsApp or SMS trees, identify safe muster points and teach members to avoid bridges or basements during cloudbursts. Preventive actions — clearing drains, securing vehicles, installing gratings — can reduce losses. When storms strike, people should move laterally to higher ground if rumbling or falling boulders are heard, and cut electricity if water seeps indoors. After the event, all water should be treated as

Urgent action is imperative.

unsafe, the damage documented, blockages reported and slopes monitored for aftershocks.

Precision in language matters. Not every heavy shower is a ‘cloudburst’. Mislabelling weakens early warnings and desensitises communities. True cloudbursts, like those in Buner or Dharali, are rare but catastrophic; distinguishing them from ordinary downpours ensures better communication, stronger preparedness and more credible risk messaging.

The new monsoon reality is stark: not gentle, season-long rainfall but violent, hyper-local downpours — weeks’ worth of water collapsing from the sky in a matter of hours. Each rain bomb can shatter homes, disrupt livelihood, and overwhelm fragile ecosystems. Yet resilience is possible. As Nobel laureate Wangari Maathai said, “It’s the little things citizens do. That’s what will make the difference. My little thing is planting trees.” Today, our collective little things — planning, preparing, protecting — become acts of survival. Afforestation, watershed protection and community vigilance remain among our strongest long-term defences against an unpredictable climate. ■

The writer has over 20 years of experience in environment and biodiversity conservation. She holds a PhD and post doctorate from Japan.

Pakistan-Saudi demand

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ISLAMABAD: Pakistan and Saudi Arabia have demanded complete withdrawal of Israeli forces from all occupied Arab territories and restitution of full national rights of the Palestinian people in their homeland, a joint communique said today [Sept 3]. The communique on Prime Minister Bhutto's visit to Saudi Arabia said the two sides took note of the current efforts being made to provide a settlement of the Middle East conflict... . "[T]he two sides reaffirmed their resolve to continue to stand by each other in all matters bearing on their national independence and territorial integrity," it said.

[Meanwhile, as reported by news agencies from the UN,] China ... charged that the Soviet Union and the United States were the biggest obstacles to Third World development. "We must take note of the fact that the two Super Powers are the biggest international exploiters and oppressors today and that they are the sources of a new world war," Chinese Foreign Trade Minister Li Chiang told the special session of the General Assembly on economic issues. Mr Li added, "at present the problem of development is ... a problem of combating imperialist and particularly Super Power control, plunder and exploitation."

Reds pushed back

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NAKTONG FRONT: Second Division men and Marines rolled Communists back south and west of Yongsan towards the Naktong river on Sunday [Sep 3] in counter-attacks that blunted the ... Red penetration of the American Western front, says [an agency] report. Second Division troops pushed due south of Yongsan against relatively light resistance to recapture ... positions overlooking the Naktong, where Red troops crossed on Saturday ... after penetrating the right flank of the American 25th Division.

West of Yongsan Marines supported by heavy artillery barrage and thunderous attacks by marine Corsair fighter planes drove the Reds off two ridges a mile and half west of Yong-san.

The Communist threat to Taegu sector ... increased as the North Koreans drove within 2,000 yards of main Tabudong to Taegu highway. The Communist thrust pushed about 3,000 yards from the Naktong River bridge-head north-east of Waegwan. There was intense fighting along the 2,000-yard front of the penetration. A First Cavalry Division spokesman said: "Next few hours will tell whether we can hold them or whether we will have to throw in more." — News agencies



Shangla is a victim of official neglect

TORRENTIAL rains and flash floods left at least 23 people dead in Shangla recently. The ongoing monsoon onslaught has destroyed houses, mosques and schools. Roads and bridges have been swept away. The district's mountainous communities remain delinked from the mainstream. And, farmland has been severely damaged, compounding the suffering of already vulnerable families.

When such disasters strike, Shangla's residents face immediate and severe disruption in electricity supply. Most villages have to depend on small, locally-built generators along the rivers. This happens even though two dams in Shangla produce around 86MW of electricity, which far exceeds the district's estimated requirement of 7MW. Yet, due to policy restrictions, the power generated in Shangla is not supplied to the local communities. As a result, when floods damage the local generators, the entire region and its people are forced to suffer in darkness.

Communication is another casualty. Internet service, already unreliable across the district, collapses almost entirely during such events. With damaged lines and disrupted signals, residents are cut off from vital information, unable to contact loved ones, or access digital resources, which is a serious handicap in an era in which connectivity is a basic necessity.

Road infrastructure, too, is a long-standing vulnerability. The road to the Kana region, serving at least 10 major villages, is a telling example. Originally constructed in 1964 under the Wali of Swat, it remained largely neglected for decades and is only now, in 2025, undergoing reconstruction — a process that began after public protests and threats.

Floods wreak havoc on such roads, and given the lethargic pace of repairs, damage

can mean years of isolation. This affects not just transportation, but also timely access to health facilities, schools and the district headquarters.

Scientific evidence shows that Pakistan is among the top 10 countries most affected by climate change. Glacial melt, erratic monsoons, and more intense rainfall events are increasing the frequency and severity of floods in regions like Shangla.

Deforestation, unregulated construction, inefficient drainage systems, and fragile infrastructure — from power lines to rural roads — compound the risk, turning heavy rains into lethal disasters.

By ignoring these factors, the government is only allowing the tragedy to keep revisiting the area year after year. Climate change adaptation is no longer optional, it is a survival imperative. Shangla's tragedy should serve as a call for urgent, coordinated action.

Strengthening infrastructure, improving early warning systems, enforcing environmental protections, upgrading communication networks, and heavily investing in disaster-resilient housing are essential steps. The government must also integrate local communities into disaster risk reduction plans, ensuring they are trained and equipped to respond.

Pakistan needs binding national and provincial policies that link climate change adaptation with development planning. Budget allocations for disaster preparedness must be treated as an investment, not a charitable afterthought.

As the people of Shangla bury their dead and rebuild their lives, the nation must move beyond fatalism, confront the reality of climate change, and commit to policies that protect lives and livelihoods.

Asad Khan
Shangla

Eastern medicine

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BEING a student of eastern medicine, I am very interested in its progress. Along with it, I am also preparing for Punjab Public Service Commission (PPSC) and Federal Public Service Commission (FPSC) examinations.

Recently, when I was applying for PPSC jobs on the basis of my graduation degree, I came across a section confined to licence-holding professions, like medicine, law and pharmacy. I was disappointed that it did not mention National Council for Tibb (NCT) licence holders.

Such an exclusion, when the government claims to be focusing on inclusive growth and development, is hurtful, as the practitioners of eastern medicine are made to struggle for due representation in spite of the contributions made by the likes of Hakim Mohammad Said for the uplift and modernisation of the field. The NCT administration should take urgent and effective steps in this regard.

Ayesha Aftab
Lahore

figures and officials. The infamous property tycoon and his mega projects in different parts of the country are known to everyone, generating transactions worth billions of rupees.

When some scheme is declared insolvent, many among those having paid only some of the instalments get no refund or delivery of property because only those having completed all payments are considered for compensation, leaving countless middle-class families with nothing but broken promises and legal dead-ends.

Illegal housing schemes also impact food security and the environment. Analysts estimate that 20-30 per cent of fertile agricultural land in Punjab has been converted into unplanned housing societies.

What is more, these schemes often lack basic sanitation, roads, or utility infrastructure. Compounding the injustice, regulatory institutions are often complicit. In several cases, illegal schemes continue operations despite formal complaints, while enforcement agencies remain weak or absent.

In Peshawar alone, 295 housing societies were declared illegal in a forensic audit, handling complaints ranging from Rs10 million to over Rs140 million in fraud per scheme.

To protect people, relevant development authorities should publish a public registry of approved schemes, and issue real-time warnings about unapproved colonies. The path forward requires courage, transparency and justice for the millions of people whose housing dreams should in no way be sacrificed at the altar of corruption.

Oshaz Fatima
Lahore

Illegal housing



ILLEGAL housing schemes, societies and towns have made one big mess for the common man across the country. According to the Rawalpindi Development Authority (RDA), over 149 illegal housing societies operate today in just one district, many deliberately unregistered and preying on unsuspecting buyers with 'RDA-approved' claims across social media and property websites.

In Punjab, according to data maintained by the provincial government, there are 7,905 housing societies, of which 5,118 are illegal or awaiting approval. These schemes lure ordinary people dreaming of owning a modest home into paying upfront sums on the basis of forged layouts and non-existent infrastructure.

In many schemes, vast portions of the proceeds vanish into the pockets of powerful developers, front men, political

responsibility towards uplifting the people's socioeconomic conditions.

According to the World Health Organisation (WHO), polluted water and poor cleanliness spread diseases like cholera, diarrhoea, dysentery, hepatitis A, typhoid and polio. It also warns that poor, insufficient, and improperly managed water and sanitation services expose people to preventable health risks. In Sindh, more than 181,000 cases of diarrhoea have been reported so far this year.

The government needs to develop a holistic policy for the coastal belt. When ready, such a policy must be implemented with the political will to support local people who deserve to have access to basic facilities, particularly potable water.

Furqan Hyder
Hyderabad

Deprived coastal belt

SINDH's coastal belt has lost its identity due to the non-availability of potable water. People have no option, but to use filthy canal water or contaminated ground water for everything, including drinking.

In September 2024, a report by the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) found that Badin, Sujawal and Thatta are the poorest districts in Sindh, with 84 per cent multidimensional poverty. Women and youth are particularly disadvantaged due to low skills and literacy levels.

The appalling situation of Sindh's coastal belt is not new; it has been deprived of potable water, livelihood opportunities, tourism, healthcare facilities and education since forever. Unfortunately, clean water, which is essential for survival, is a rare commodity.

There are a few non-governmental organisations (NGOs) that are working for the betterment of people in rural areas, but the government cannot shrug off its

Kidnappers free Wana school head after two weeks

By Our Correspondent

SOUTH WAZIRISTAN: Kidnappers freed school principal and president of Wana welfare association Rahmatullah Wazir on Wednesday night after keeping him in their captivity for two weeks.

Lower South Waziristan district police officer Mohammad Tahir Shah confirmed that the principal of New Iqra Public School, Wana, had safely returned home while his family also affirmed his wellbeing.

According to police sources, following the announcement of his release, the Wana schools union called off its sit-in outside Government High School, Wana.

Union president Humayun Wazir said the development would help restore an environment conducive for education and reduce anxiety among parents and students.

It merits a mention here that two weeks ago, armed men intercepted Rahmatullah Wazir while he was on his way to school from home, abducting him near Mughalkhel village. The assailants had also opened fire, injuring two civilians.

Police said investigations were under way, but declined to share further details.

Following his release, Wana schools' union president Humayun Wazir expressed gratitude to private school principals, students, political and social leaders, journalists, tribal elders, the district administration, police and security forces for their support during the crisis.

The incident comes against the backdrop of worsening law and order in Waziristan region over the past year.

Local accounts indicate a surge in bomb blasts, kidnapping for ransom, targeted killing, and attacks on police and security checkpoints, fueling a growing sense of insecurity among residents.

Residents, including social activists and parents, have urged the federal government and security forces to take immediate and coordinated measures to restore peace, ensuring that educational activities can continue without fear.

They expressed hope that those involved in the kidnapping would be brought to justice and that effective strategies would be put in place to prevent such incidents in the future.

Lakki peace body members survive bomb attack

Page 8

By Our Correspondent

LAKKI MARWAT: Local residents and members of a peace committee survived a bomb attack in the Sherikhel area of Lakki Marwat district on Tuesday night, the police said.

An official said that an explosive device attached to a motorcycle parked alongside a mosque by suspected terrorists went off with a bang, panicking the villagers.

“The blast was heard in the entire locality but luckily it did not cause any casualties,” the official said.

He said that a portion of the outer wall of the mosque was partially damaged in the explosion.

Meanwhile, funeral prayers of the martyrs of the Bannu terrorist attack were offered in the cantonment area on Wednesday.

KP chief secretary Shahab Ali Shah, IGP Zulfiqar Hameed and Commandant Federal Constabulary Mohammad Riaz Nazir Gara, regional police officer Sajjad Khan, district police officer Saleem Abbas Kulachi, Counter-Terrorism Department SP Fazal Wahid and other police officials were in attendance.

A soldier of the Pakistan army and five FC personnel had lost their lives in an intense exchange of fire with terrorists after a suicide attack on the Federal Constabulary compound.

Government officials placed floral wreaths on the coffins of martyrs while an alert FC contingent presented a final salute to them.

On the occasion, the chief secretary and provincial police officer condemned the cowardly terrorist attack on the Federal Constabulary compound and paid rich tributes to the martyrs who laid down their lives for the defence of the motherland.

They said that the supreme sacrifices offered by brave sons of the soil would not go in vain; adding that the police, FC and other security forces were ready at all times to thwart nefarious plans of terrorists against the country and its people.

They said that the fight would continue until the last terrorist was eliminated. They said the state and the people shared equally the grief of the families of the martyrs.

They added that the sacrifice offered by the martyrs was a guarantee of peace, tranquility and a secure future for the coming generations.

Later, the chief secretary, the IGP and FC commandant visited the Combined Military Hospital, Bannu, where they enquired after the injured army and FC soldiers.

Programmes with low enrolments to be discontinued in KP colleges

Page 8

Official says
'market-oriented'
subjects to be
introduced

By Mohammad Ashfaq

PESHAWAR: The Khyber Pakhtunkhwa higher education department has decided to discontinue certain programmes in government colleges due to low enrolments.

An official told *Dawn* that the higher education department had identified 39 disciplines, taught in 35 government colleges across the province, for discontinuation, while the rest of the subjects would remain unaffected.

"The courses with five or six enrolled students will be closed down," he said.

The official said it was actually tantamount to the "misuse of government resources" to continue with programmes with low enrolments, while the students were reluctant to take

admissions in such subjects as they didn't have any "value" in the job market.

He rejected media reports about the plans to discontinue the Bachelor of Studies (BS) programme in government colleges.

The official, however, said that the department had closed down BS (Pashto) programme at Abbottabad's Government Postgraduate College No 1, BS (Political Science) at Abbottabad's Government Postgraduate College for Women and BS (Islmiat) at Abbottabad's Qalandabad Government Postgraduate College.

He said the same was the case with other districts.

"After the closure of such programmes, we'll introduce market-oriented subjects in government colleges," he said.

The HED has also decided to introduce an associate degree programme in a couple of disciplines, replacing the BS degree programme in 128 colleges of the province.

The official told *Dawn* that an associate degree programme

has been introduced in those disciplines where enrolment had decreased with the passage of time. Under the associate degree programme, the students can continue their education by taking admission in the fifth semester of the BS programme.

"In fact the course of the BS programme has been split and named as an associate degree programme," he said.

The official said the associate degree programme was equal to the BA/BSc degrees and the holders of associate degree programmes could get jobs with it.

He said that the associate degree programme was already functioning in the government colleges located in the rural and far off areas of the province.

One of the professors of a government degree college criticised HED for taking "ill-planned" decisions regarding new subjects and degree programmes.

"The department extended the BS programme to all government colleges without ensuring required faculty and facilities,"

he said.

A notification read that the directorate of HED had undertaken a comprehensive review of the Bachelor of Science (BS) and Associate Degree (AD) programmes currently offered in the government colleges to assess existing resources and align future academic offerings with strategic needs.

It added that the review identified several critical challenges, including high dropout rates and low student enrollment in certain BS programmes.

According to the notification, it has been observed that a significant number of BS disciplines, often with limited market relevance, are consuming a disproportionate share of resources. This has constrained the department's ability to introduce new, market-aligned programmes that better serve the students' interests.

"To optimise resource utilisation and create a more conducive and relevant academic environment, a dedicated BS Committee was constituted by the department. The committee has thoroughly reviewed the

existing BS programme currently offerings, with a specific focus on creating space for market aligned disciplines. Based on the committee's recommendations, which have been duly approved by the competent authority, it had been decided to close the selected BS programmes with immediate effect," read the notification.

It added that selected colleges would fully or partially transition from BS programmes to Associate Degree programmes.

The notification said those colleges would initiate subject-based Associate Degree programmes after formal permission from the department.

"This strategic shift is designed to strengthen the academic foundation of our colleges and ensure the efficient and effective use of departmental resources, hence, shall be implemented in true spirit," it said.

The notification added that BS colleges were allowed to initiate BS admissions through online portal specifically in the approved subjects.

Girls outshine boys in Dera board HSSC exam

DERA ISMAIL KHAN: Girls secured the top positions in the higher secondary school certificate examination results declared by the Board of Intermediate and Secondary Education, Dera Ismail Khan, on Wednesday.

The announcement was made at an award distribution ceremony, where Dera city mayor Sardar Umar Amin Khan Gandapur was the chief guest.

Results showed that Dua Zainab of Iqra Science School and College, Paharpur, clinched the overall first position by securing 1,154 marks. Mustabshira Miftah of Leeds School and College stood second with 1,145 marks, while Dua of Qurtuba Public School and College secured third position with 1,144 marks.

In the pre-engineering group, Noor Fatima of Leeds College secured first position with 1,122 marks. Amjadullah of Cadet College, Spinkai South Waziristan, stood second with 1,111 marks, while Mohammad Shamis of Cadet College, Wana, took third place with 1,110 marks.

In the general science group, Nuzhat Fatima of Iqra School, Paharpur bagged the first position with 1,141 marks, followed by Usama Khan (1,130 marks) and Mohammad Waleed (1,129 marks), both from Cadet College Spinkai, securing second and third positions, respectively.

In the arts group, Mohammad Jawad Ali Khan of Government Higher Secondary School No 1, Paharpur secured first position with 1,043 marks. Jamila Sadia of Government Girls Higher Secondary School, Paharpur obtained second position with 1,018 marks, while Naila Shah of Government Girls Degree College, Tank stood third with 1,015 marks.

Speaking on the occasion, city mayor Umar Amin Gandapur congratulated the position holders and attributed their success to the dedication of teachers and the prayers of parents. He said reforms were being introduced in the Dera board on the directives of the provincial government.

Despite working from a rented building, he added the board was moving towards digitalisation, and soon a purpose-built building with modern facilities would be established. — Correspondent

Reassessment of Malakand flood damage cuts rehab costs

Page 8

PESHAWAR: A reassessment of last month's flood damage and rehabilitation needs in the Malakand Division has reduced the estimated costs from Rs12.2 billion to Rs5.79 billion.

Officials told *Dawn* that the local government department carried out the "re-verification" of damage, which was reported by authorities at the village and neighbourhood council level, the only grassroots government in the province.

A senior official said a "three-tier mechanism" was used to check the damage assessment reports received from the district administration.

The documents show that after the Aug 15 rains, which caused over 400 casualties and widespread infrastructure damage across Malakand Division, the provincial government tasked local government secretary Saqib Raza Aslam with "coordinating collection of the data of the damage assessed by the communication and works, public health engineering, local government and irrigation departments, and prepare rehabilitation plans.

They noted that the damage assessment exercise began from the offices of the Water and Sanitation Services Company Swat following a visit to the flood-affected areas and it was decided to limit the assessment to damage incurred after the early hours of Aug 15 and it would be geo-tagged.

The documents also revealed

that it was decided that the restoration would mean rehabilitating infrastructure to what it was on Aug 14, while the complete rehabilitation would be reported and calculated separately. Also, the LG teams will assess damages and calculate rehabilitation independently as a third party verification.

The damage assessment reports submitted by the relevant departments were scrutinised thrice between August 19 and 25.

The assessment carried by the line departments put the cost of rehabilitation of 538 damaged development schemes at over Rs12.2 billion with the communication and works department claiming the major chunk of losses worth over Rs7 billion. The irrigation department came up with the figure of Rs4.7 billion and the public health engineering department with Rs442 million.

The documents noted that LG department through its field formations "re-verified" the estimated costs of rehabilitation.

They showed that teams were constituted comprising the secretary of the village and neighbourhood council, sub-engineer, patwari halqa, assistant engineer, assistant director and senior official of district administration. Also, elected representatives and secretaries of every village and neighbourhood council also independently reported whether or not their area was affected.

The documents revealed that the teams later visited every affected project site and took feedback from the community as well, while the damage was assessed on a predefined proforma. Teams of the director general (monitoring and evaluation) at the planning and development department were asked to help "cross-verify" LG teams' working.

The documents said that the re-verification showed that the schemes damaged before Aug 15 were also included for rehabilitation. In addition, on several occasions, geo-tags were found missing and the schemes slated as damaged were duplicated.

The LG department's exercise showed that out of 1,053 village and neighbourhood councils in eight districts of Malakand division, just 273 were affected by the Aug 15 rains and floods.

The final damage assessment report revealed that a total of 923 development schemes were damaged in 273 village and neighbourhood councils of the Malakand Division, including 238 roads, 109 bridges, 87 drinking water supply schemes, 91 irrigation channels, 212 retaining walls, 154 sanitation schemes and 32 public buildings. The exercise put the cost of the rehabilitation of the damaged facilities at Rs5.7 billion compared instead of the initial Rs12.2 billion, according to documents. — Manzoor Ali

Millers flay Punjab 'ban' on wheat movement

Page 8

Bureau Report

PESHAWAR: All Pakistan Flour Mills Association, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa chapter has flayed the Punjab government over 'imposition' of ban on the interprovincial movement of wheat, calling it 'unconstitutional', and feared that KP might face flour crisis if the restriction was not lifted forthwith.

Addressing a joint press conference following a meeting here on Wednesday, Sarhad Chamber of Commerce and Industry president Fazal Moqem Khan and the association's KP chairman Naeem Butt

accused the Punjab government of halting supply of wheat to Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, and described it as sheer violation of Article 151 of the Constitution.

They elaborated that Punjab authorities had erected a special checkpoint, barring wheat-laden vehicles from entering KP, calling it as economic terrorism. They said KP was facing a huge deficit of wheat and was dependent on procurement from open market.

Mr Moqem and Mr Butt said KP was facing a shortfall of 41,000 metric tonnes of wheat as the province's total production was 12,000 metric tonnes against its demand of 51,000 metric tonnes.

They said a substantial increase in flour prices was witnessed after restrictions on supply of wheat to KP from Punjab were imposed, forcing people to buy flour at high rates. They warned of further increase if the ban was not lifted immediately.

Mr Moqem and Mr Butt pointed out that wheat sector had been deregulated under an agreement with the IMF, after which wheat and flour were put under an open market mechanism, barring the government from determining prices of wheat and flour and imposing any kind of restrictions on movement of wheat.

They said the Punjab government had defied the constitu-

tional provision and the IMF agreement by banning movement on August 26, opening ways of corruption for police and other authorities. They alleged that Rs150,000 was being charged per truck as bribe at various illegal checkpoints.

They said such decisions had never proved productive in the past, and had always given birth to crisis. They claimed that the move was aimed at creating wheat crisis in the KP province.

Mr Moqem and Mr Butt said thousands of tonnes of wheat was available with the government in carry-forward stock, but even then such tactics were used in a bid to create artificial

shortage, which would not only hit the ordinary citizens but the flour industry as well.

They appealed to the army chief Field Marshal Gen Asim Munir, Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, Federal Minister for National Food Security and Research Rana Tanveer Hussain and KP Chief Minister Gandapur to immediately intervene in the matter to avert flour crisis in KP.

They emphasised the need for ensuring free inter-provincial trade and cracking down on 'extortion mafia'. They announced that they would decide future course of action if the ban was not lifted immediately.

Unexpected rise in cotton arrivals despite floods

Page 9

Lint production increases by 9pc driven mainly by a surge in Sindh

By Amjad Mahmood

LAHORE: In a surprising turn, cotton production in Pakistan has seen an unexpected increase this season, defying earlier predictions despite widespread heavy rainfall and flooding in key cotton-growing regions.

While the increase marks a positive development, the sector still faces significant challenges, with large areas of cotton crops submerged by floods, especially in Punjab. The floodwaters are now heading towards Sindh, threatening further damage.

According to the latest report from the Pakistan Cotton Ginners Association (PCGA) released on Wednesday, as of Aug 31, ginneries across the country had received 1.336 million bales of raw cotton, reflecting a 9 per cent increase over the same period last year.

The rise has been largely driven by a notable surge in cotton arrivals from Sindh, where production is up by 87pc compared to Punjab. In fact, ginneries in Sindh received 352,000 bales between Aug 16 and 31, a sharp increase from 226,000 bales in the first half of August and a substantial jump from 130,000 bales in the same period last year. This brings the total for Sindh to 1.336 million bales, a 13pc increase compared to 2024, despite the adverse weather conditions.

In contrast, cotton arrivals in Punjab have shown a more modest increase. Ginneries in the province received 466,000 bales by Aug 31, which is a 3pc rise compared to the same period last year. However, a separate report from the Crop Reporting Service Punjab indicated a record 125pc increase in cotton production in the province compared to the PCGA's data.

Industry challenges persist

Despite the early positive figures, experts warn that the sector's future remains uncertain. Ihsan Ul Haq, Chairman of the Cotton Ginners Forum, cautioned that the full impact of the floods and rains will only be clear once the adverse weather conditions subside. While many cotton zones have experienced only minor damage, Bahawalnagar, Pakistan's largest cotton-producing district, has reportedly seen a 50% loss in its crop.

Moreover, a recent report by the International Cotton Advisory Committee (ICAC) projected a deficit of 100,000 tonnes (around 625,000 bales) in Pakistan's total cotton production this year due to the weather-related disruptions.

Sajid Mahmood, an industry expert, explained that although initial reports show positive figures, they do not paint the full picture. Severe heatwaves, floods, and water shortages have put immense pressure on the cotton crop.

Envoy urges US firms to invest in Pakistan

Page 9

ISLAMABAD: The acting US Ambassador to Pakistan, Natalie Baker, has urged American companies to invest in and expand their operations in Pakistan.

Ms Baker praised the government's efforts under Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif to reform the economy and create a more investor-friendly environment. She also emphasised Pakistan's strategic advantages, including its large consumer market, competitive labour costs, and strategic location.

Speaking at a webinar organised by the Business Council for International Understanding (BCIU), Ms Baker highlighted key sectors with potential for US investment, including critical minerals, information and communications technology, agriculture, energy, and infrastructure development. The event brought together business leaders and financial institutions from both the US and Pakistan to discuss the evolving business landscape and economic reforms in Pakistan, according to a US Embassy press release issued on Wednesday.

"This is the fifth-largest country in the world, with a population of 250 million people, 64pc of whom are under the age of 30. Pakistan represents one of the world's largest and youngest consumer markets. Its GDP stands at about \$412bn, ranked 38th globally, but Goldman Sachs projects it could reach \$3.3tr by 2050, placing it among the top 10 to 15 economies," she said.—Amin Ahmed

Cement, fertiliser power PSX to new peak

Page 5

KSE-100 index settles above 152,000 points despite economic challenges

By Muhammad Kashif

KARACHI: Despite a slump in exports and the devastating impact of recent floods, the Pakistan Stock Exchange (PSX) continued its bullish trend, marking the fourth consecutive session of gains. The benchmark KSE-100 index surged past the 152,000-point barrier, reaching an all-time high, buoyed by strong performances from the cement and fertiliser sectors.

Ahsan Mehanti of Arif Habib Corporation attributed the market's record close to the optimistic GDP growth projections by the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP), ranging between 3.25pc and 4.25pc for FY26. Additionally, speculation surrounding trade relations under CPEC 2.0 and the Pak-China Free Trade Agreement, along with stronger-than-expected sectoral data, contributed to the bullish momentum.

Pakistan's merchandise exports, however,

PAKISTAN STOCK EXCHANGE

T H E T O P F I V E R S			
G A I N E R S		L O S E R S	
Hoechst Pakistan	210.03	Unilever Foods	281.29
PIA Holding CoB	158.30	Rathan Maize	68.89
Sitara Chemical Ind	65.93	JDW Sugar Mills	36.51
Service Industries	47.20	Khyber Textile	34.31
Abbott Lab	46.10	Siemens Pakistan	17.35
L E A D E R S *			
Pace Pakistan	89.28		
Fauji Foods	73.36		
The Bank of Punjab	51.57		
The Hub Power Co	38.20		
Waves Corporation	36.97		

(Share values in rupees)

* Volume in millions of traded shares

I N D I C A T O R S			
	Wednesday	Previous	Change
KSE 100-SHARE INDEX (Points)	152,201.88	150,975.48	▲ 1,226.4
KSE 30-SHARE INDEX (Points)	46,354.00	45,968.76	▲ 385.24
MARKET CAPITAL (Rs billion)	17,963.721	17,855.530	▲ 108.190
TRADING VALUE (Rs billion)	51.308	44.424	▲ 6.884

remained in negative territory in August, raising concerns among policy-makers about diminishing global demand and the country's declining competitiveness. This marks the fourth contraction in exports over the past five months, with only a brief respite in July due to marginal growth. The persistent decline highlights the increasing pressure on the nation's trade performance, as exporters grapple with subdued external demand and rising business costs.

According to Topline

Securities, the stock market continued to rally, with the KSE-100 index recording an intraday high of 1,829 points before settling at 152,201 points, a gain of 1,226 points or 0.81pc.

Investor sentiment remained positive, fuelled by strong sectoral performances. The cement sector, in particular, saw notable gains, driven by a 12pc year-on-year (YoY) increase in despatches in August, boosting overall optimism in the market.

The fertiliser sector also attracted significant

investor interest, with urea sales rising 46pc YoY and 34pc month-on-month (MoM) to reach 816,000 tonnes in August. This surge was supported by aggressive discounting from select manufacturers and the anticipation of a partial rollback in September.

Hub Power, from the power sector, also contributed to the bullish sentiment, reporting robust 4QFY25 results with earnings of Rs9.16 per share and a Rs10 per share dividend — higher than market expectations. This

brought its full-year payout to Rs15 per share.

On the index front, major support came from Hub Power, Fauji Fertiliser, Oil and Gas Development Company (OGDC), Mari Petroleum, and Pakistan Petroleum collectively adding another 198 points to the index. Despite the challenges posed by external factors such as the trade deficit and floods, the 150,000-point mark now appears to be a solid floor for the market. Investor optimism remains high, bolstered by expectations of a relief package for farmers and hopes of a resolution to the power sector's circular debt issue. With strong liquidity and continued momentum, bulls are now eyeing even higher levels in the sessions to come.

shares traded.

Ali Najib, Deputy Head of Trading at Arif Habib Ltd, noted that the PSX had indeed made history by closing at a record high of 152,202 points. The surge was also driven by encouraging trade deficit numbers and stronger-than-expected offtake figures for cement and urea.

The standout performer of the session was Hub Power, which posted an impressive Rs10 dividend alongside its FY25 results, delivering an earnings per share (EPS) of Rs10.29 for 4QFY25. Its stock price jumped 8.1pc, lifting the index by 405 points. This triggered similar gains in the exploration and production (E&P) sector, with OGDC, Mari Petroleum, and Pakistan Petroleum collectively adding another 198 points to the index. Despite the challenges posed by external factors such as the trade deficit and floods, the 150,000-point mark now appears to be a solid floor for the market. Investor optimism remains high, bolstered by expectations of a relief package for farmers and hopes of a resolution to the power sector's circular debt issue. With strong liquidity and continued momentum, bulls are now eyeing even higher levels in the sessions to come.

ACTIVITY

Total listed	532
Active	477
Gainers	242
Losers	204

PARTICIPANTS

Foreign	▼ \$0.43m
Companies	▲ \$0.13m
Banks	▼ \$4.57m
Mutual Funds	▲ \$0.50m
Individuals	▲ \$3.22m

Gold hits Page 9 Rs376,000 per tola

By Aamir Shafaat Khan

KARACHI: Gold prices in Pakistan surged to new all-time highs on Wednesday, continuing the upward trend in the global market. The price of 10 grams of 24kt gold reached Rs322,959, while one tola of the precious metal soared to Rs376,700, marking an increase of Rs5,144 and Rs6,000, respectively, compared to Tuesday's rates.

According to the All Pakistan Sarafa Gems and Jewellers Association (APSGJA), the previous record for 10 grams and one tola was set on September 1, 2024, when prices hit Rs317,815 and Rs370,800, respectively, based on a world gold price of \$3,480 per ounce. On Wednesday, the global gold price stood at \$3,540 per ounce, reflecting a \$60 per ounce increase from the previous day.

Mohammad Qasim Shikarpuri, President of APSGJA, attributed the rising trend in global gold prices to uncertainty surrounding potential interest rate cuts by the US Federal Reserve and strong investor demand.

He also pointed to silver's increasing role in supporting gold prices, noting that gold had previously faced pressure due to geopolitical tensions, including the Ukraine-Russia conflict, the Israel-Gaza war, and US tariffs.

The prices of silver have also increased. The cost of 10 grams of 24kt silver reached Rs3,699, while one-tola is priced at Rs4,315, reflecting an increase of Rs10 and Rs12 from Tuesday's rates. The international price of silver stands at \$4,082 per ounce.

Govt raises Rs515bn as banks overbid

Page 9

Despite excess liquidity, slow credit flow to private sector raises concerns

By Shahid Iqbal

KARACHI: The government surpassed its target in Wednesday's treasury bill auction, raising Rs515.2bn, with banks offering more than three times the targeted amount.

However, despite the oversubscription, the cut-off yields remained largely unchanged, with a slight reduction of 14bps for one-month papers, bringing the yield down from 10.89pc to 10.75pc.

The government raised Rs402.7bn through the direct auction, while an additional Rs112.5bn was secured via uncompetitive bids. The original target for the auction was Rs400bn, but the strong demand from banks and the corporate sector, driven by excess liquidity, pushed the total raised amount well beyond the target. Bids for the treasury bills amounted to Rs1.477 trillion, reflecting the abundance of liquidity within the banking system.

However, this also highlighted the fact that banks are holding substantial funds without lending to the private sector, despite the low interest rate of 11pc.

The lack of private sector borrowing is a point of concern. While the govern-

ment insists that the economy is on the right track, industries, particularly the textile sector, have been vocal in requesting urgent assistance to lower the cost of doing business. This lack of credit flow to trade and industry suggests that the low interest rates and recent decline in inflation to 3.2pc in August have not been enough to stimulate private sector investment.

Analysts have pointed to the uncertainty surrounding Pakistan's political situation as a key reason for the hesitation among investors. Moreover, banks remain cautious, mainly due to the government's status as the largest borrower in the country. Experts have noted that the full extent of economic damage from the recent floods will only become clear once the situation stabilises. The floods are expected to significantly increase government spending, particularly on relief efforts, while revenue collection may fall short of targets.

Bankers anticipate that the government's increased spending due to flood relief efforts will further strain fiscal resources, and the damage caused by the floods could impact the economy for the foreseeable future. The government has already announced plans to borrow Rs4 trillion through domestic bonds between September and November this year, underlining the urgent need for funds to manage flood-related expenditures.

Senate committee proposes key changes to Virtual Assets Bill

Page 9

Recommends barring PVARA members from trading; proposes placing authority under Finance Division

By Khaleeq Kiani

ISLAMABAD: The Senate Standing Committee on Finance and Revenue on Wednesday recommended that members and staff of the Pakistan Virtual Asset Regulatory Authority (PVARA) be barred from trading in virtual assets. The committee also suggested placing the authority under

the Finance Division rather than the Cabinet Division.

During discussions on the government's Virtual Assets Bill 2025, PMLN Senator Afnanullah Khan accused the Secretary of Law of plagiarism. He claimed that he had originally tabled the bill, which was later "copy-pasted" by the Ministry of Law and introduced as the government's version. "This is shameful," he said, adding that the government's draft was identical to the one he had proposed, which had been opposed by the government earlier.

Senator Saleem Mandviwalla, who chaired the meeting, criticised the practice of the government claiming credit for draft laws initially proposed by members. He

pointed out that such instances had occurred multiple times in the past, with the government only acting when parliamentarians introduced new bills. Senator Dilawar Khan likened the situation to someone claiming ownership of Mirza Ghalib's poetry.

Secretary of Law Raja Naeem Akbar denied having seen Mr Khan's private member bill until the Senate panel provided it. However, Senator Afnanullah maintained that the law minister had seen and opposed his bill when it was first introduced. He proposed a privilege motion in the Senate, accusing the Law Secretary of misleading Parliament by claiming the bill was never presented.

The committee also recom-

mended setting eligibility criteria for members and the chairman of PVARA, including a minimum of five years of experience and an age limit of 55 years. Senator Afnanullah suggested stronger safeguards for data privacy, and proposed that service providers be held accountable for privacy violations.

Senators Mandviwalla and Mohsin Aziz raised concerns over the \$10,000 limit on virtual asset transactions, suggesting that there should be no such cap if the government is determined to regulate virtual assets.

The government had issued a presidential ordinance on July 8 to establish an independent regulator for virtual assets and service pro-

viders. The regulator will have comprehensive powers to ensure transparency, compliance, and prevent illicit activities such as money laundering and terrorism financing, in line with international standards set by the Financial Action Task Force (FATF).

PVARA's board will include key government figures such as the State Bank's governor, and the secretaries of finance, law, and information technology, as well as the chairpersons of the Securities and Exchange Commission of Pakistan (SECP), Federal Board of Revenue (FBR), and Digital Pakistan Authority. Two independent directors with expertise in virtual assets, law, finance, or technology will also be appointed by the fed-

eral government.

Under the bill, any person or company wishing to offer virtual asset services in or from Pakistan must be licensed by PVARA. The bill outlines a structured licensing regime with specific requirements for operational capacity, compliance frameworks, and reporting obligations.

The bill aims to ensure investor protection, promote transparency, and foster innovation in the virtual asset market.

The government has also ensured that the regulatory framework will be compatible with Islamic finance principles by mandating the creation of a Sharia Advisory Committee to advise PVARA on Sharia compliance for virtual asset products and services.

Wapda seeks to double revenue requirement

By Khaleeq Kiani

ISLAMABAD: The Water and Power Development Authority (Wapda) has sought about a 91 per cent increase in its revenue requirement to Rs365 billion for the current fiscal year (FY26), up from Rs191bn in FY23.

This would translate into an estimated 90pc increase in the bulk hydropower rate to about Rs11.55 per unit (kilowatt hour) from Rs6.10 per unit, an official told *Dawn*.

The additional revenue of about Rs174bn demanded by Wapda for FY26 also covers an unaddressed financial gap of Rs22.35bn for FY23, Rs56bn for FY24 and Rs61bn for FY25. The Rs365bn revenue requirement further includes Rs29.5bn net hydel profit (NHP) to Khyber Pakhtunkhwa at Rs1.55 per unit, Rs11.7bn to Punjab at Rs1.47 per unit, and Rs5bn in water use charges to Azad Kashmir at Rs1.10 per unit.

The National Electric Power Regulatory Authority (Nepra) has scheduled a public hearing on September 11 to assess whether Wapda's claim is justified for an 85pc increase in return on investments and operations and maintenance (O&M) to Rs179bn in FY26, compared to Rs97bn determined in FY23.

This includes Wapda's demand for raising O&M expenses from Rs24bn in FY23 to Rs30.665bn in FY24, Rs36.374bn in FY25 and Rs39.59bn in FY26 — a 67pc increase. The claims also include a depreciation charge of Rs7.924bn in FY24, Rs8.611bn in FY25 and Rs8.7bn in FY26. Nepra has also raised questions about Wapda's demand for a weighted average cost of capital (WACC)-based return on power stations of Rs31.582bn, Rs32.294bn and Rs32.011bn for FY24, FY25 and FY26, respectively. Similarly, the request for WACC-based return on investment in power projects amounting to Rs59.783bn, Rs78.408bn and Rs99.642bn for the same three years is under scrutiny.

Overall, Wapda has sought its own revenue requirement at Rs318.5bn for FY26 — an almost 166pc increase compared to Rs119.962bn in FY23. In addition, Wapda has kept its estimates relatively stable for levies and dues payable to the provinces and AJK on account of NHP and water use charges.

Annual NHP payments to KP are estimated at Rs29.53bn for FY26 compared to Rs30bn in FY23. Similar payments to Punjab are booked at Rs11.969bn for FY26 against Rs11.867bn in FY23, while water use charges for AJK are projected at Rs5.085bn in FY26 against Rs4.222bn in FY23. Wapda's power generation from all assets is projected at 31,563 gigawatt hours (GWh) in FY26, slightly up from 31,286GWh in FY23.

A key issue for scrutiny will be Wapda's request to carve out 20MW for a wheeling arrangement to Sky47 — a special purpose vehicle (SPV) of Mari Energy — for data centres of strategic and commercial use, in line with the competitive trading bilateral contract market (CTBCM), along with provisions for post-retirement benefits of Wapda employees.



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WAPDA has sought a 91pc revenue hike for FY26, including a significant rise in hydropower tariff and operational expenses, amid financial scrutiny.—File

Seven migrants found dead on Spanish beaches

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MADRID: Seven migrants were found dead on two beaches in southern Spain on Wednesday after their boats sank, local authorities said.

Six bodies were discovered at dawn on Los Muertos beach in Carboneras in the southern region of Andalusia, while another was found on the nearby Las Salinas beach in Cabo de Gata, a source close to the investigation said.

The shipwrecks happened overnight but the bodies were discovered at dawn. Twenty-six migrants were rescued from a boat which ran aground on the Los Muertos beach. It was not clear how many people in total were travelling on it. The other boat which reached Cabo da Gata was carrying 38 people.

The authorities have not ruled out the possibility of finding more bodies in the area in the coming hours. The migrants are believed to have departed from Algeria, the source said.

Spain is one of the three main entry points for irregular migrants heading for Europe, along with Italy and Greece. Authorities say thousands have died in recent years attempting the Atlantic crossing from Africa, mainly toward Spain's Canary Islands.—AFP

Cosmetics chain shut for a day

Page 10

protest

LONDON: British cosmetics chain Lush on Wednesday shut down its UK shops, factories and online sales for the day to protest the devastating humanitarian effects of Israel's war in Gaza.

The international retailer said it displayed signs reading "stop starving Gaza — we are closed in solidarity" across shuttered shop windows.

"Whilst Lush is losing a day of takings, this also means that the UK government is losing a day of tax contributions from Lush and our customers," the company, which sells its products in over 50 countries, said on its website. Lush said it "shares the anguish that millions of people feel seeing the images of starving people in Gaza" and called for the UK government to end arms sales to Israel.

London has in recent months suspended some export licences to Israel for arms used in Gaza. Lush, which has over 100 shops in Britain, faced a backlash in 2023 after a Dublin store displayed a sign urging "boycott Israel", which the company called an "isolated" incident.—AFP

US kills 11 in strike on 'drug boat' from Venezuela

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Pentagon chief suggests more operations against cartels coming

WASHINGTON: The US military killed 11 people on Tuesday in a strike on a vessel from Venezuela allegedly carrying illegal narcotics, President Donald Trump said, in the first known operation since his administration's recent deployment of warships to the southern Caribbean.

"We just, over the last few minutes, literally shot out a boat, a drug-carrying boat, a lot of drugs in that boat," Trump told reporters at the White House. "And there's more where that came from. We have a lot of drugs pouring into our country, coming in for a long time ... These came out of Venezuela." He later shared a video on his Truth Social platform that appeared to show footage from overhead drones of a speedboat at sea exploding and then on fire.

"The strike resulted in 11 terrorists killed in action. No US Forces were harmed in this strike," Trump said. He

added that the US military had identified the crew as members of Venezuelan gang Tren de Aragua, which the US designated a terrorist group in February. He repeated allegations that Tren de Aragua is being controlled by Venezuela's President Nicolas Maduro, accusations that Caracas denies.

Venezuela's Communications Minister, Freddy Nanez, suggested in a post on social media that the video shared by Trump was created with artificial intelligence.

The decision to blow up a suspected drug vessel passing through the Caribbean, instead of seizing the vessel and apprehending its crew, is highly unusual and evokes memories of the US fight against militant groups like Al Qaeda.

"Being suspected of carrying drugs" doesn't carry a death sentence," said Adam Isacson, Director for Defense Oversight at the Washington Office on Latin America, in a post on X.

US warships in Caribbean

The United States has deployed warships in the southern Caribbean in recent weeks with the aim of following through on a pledge by Trump to crack

down on drug cartels.

Seven US warships, along with one nuclear-powered fast attack submarine, are either in the region or expected to be there soon, carrying more than 4,500 sailors and Marines.

While US Coast Guard and Navy ships regularly operate in the Southern Caribbean, the current buildup exceeds the usual deployments in the region. In the naval force are warships, including USS San Antonio, USS Iwo Jima, and USS Fort Lauderdale. Some can carry aerial assets like helicopters while others can also deploy Tomahawk cruise missiles.

Pentagon operations

US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth said that military operations against cartels would continue, setting the stage for a sustained military campaign in Latin America even as basic questions about a deadly strike against a vessel from Venezuela remained unanswered.

"We've got assets in the air, assets in the water, assets on ships, because this is a deadly serious mission for us, and it won't stop with just this strike," Hegseth said on Fox News.—Reuters

Australia to pay Nauru \$1.62bn to house deportees

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UN, rights groups slam resettlement of 80,000 immigrants in tiny Pacific country of 12,000 people

SYDNEY: Australia has agreed to pay the tiny Pacific nation of Nauru \$1.62 billion over three decades to host deported non-citizens, with accommodation for the first deportees already prepared, Australian officials said on Wednesday.

Prime Minister Anthony Albanese's centre-left government is expected to pass a law on Thursday making it easier to deport non-citizens to third countries, reviving criticism from human rights groups that it was "dumping" refugees in small island states and drawing comparisons with US President Donald Trump's immigration policies.

Australia signed a deal with Nauru to resettle people who have been denied refugee visas because of criminal convictions. The United States is seeking Pacific Island nations willing to accept deported non-citizens. The planned new law removes procedural fairness when Australia deports a non-citizen to a third country and is designed to limit court appeals, the government said. It is expected to pass in parliament after the conservative opposition Liberal Party said it would support the move.

Australia will pay Nauru an upfront A\$400 million to establish an endowment fund for the resettlement scheme, plus A\$70 million annually for the 30-year life of the agreement, Australian officials told a parliamentary committee.

The funds can be clawed back by Australia if Nauru

decides not to accept as many deportees as expected, the home affairs officials added. Nauru was already involved in Australia's policies on immigration: two-thirds of its revenue last year, or \$129.96 million, came from hosting an Australian-funded processing centre for asylum seekers.

Under a decade-old policy to discourage people smuggling, Australia sends asylum seekers who arrive by boat to offshore detention centres to have refugee claims assessed, denying them Australian visas. The practice has been criticised by the United Nations Human Rights Committee.

Several independent lawmakers said they were concerned it could be applied more widely than the 350 released by the High Court decision, with up to 80,000 people in the community without a visa.

Nauru, which has a population of 12,000 and a land area of just 21 square km (eight square miles), is reliant on foreign aid, and faces a 2025 deadline to repay Taiwan \$27.94 million after switching diplomatic ties to Beijing, according to budget documents.

The new Nauru resettlement scheme will cover a different group, whose visas were cancelled by Australia because they served prison sentences or were refused visas on character grounds, and cannot return to countries including Iran, Myanmar and Iraq because of the risk of persecution.—Reuters

Dhaka eyes end to mystery of last Nawab's treasure trove

Page 10

DHAKA: For more than a century, the fate of the dazzling Darya-i-Noor (River of Light) diamond has been sealed inside a bank vault — a mystery that haunts Khawaja Naim Murad, great-grandson of the last Nawab of Dhaka.

Locked away in 1908, were the family's heirlooms lost during the violence at the end of British rule in 1947? Did they survive the 1971 break-up of Pakistan and the string of coups that followed in Bangladesh, or are they still safe, dusty but untouched?

Many suspect the jewels are long gone, and officials at a state-run bank in Dhaka hesitate to simply open the vault, fearing they'd carry the cost if it is empty.

But the cash-strapped Bangladesh government has now ordered a committee to unseal the vault — and Murad clings to hope.

"This is not a fairytale," said Murad, 55, recounting a story passed down from his father about the giant diamond, the centre-piece rock of glittering armband.

"The diamond was rectangular in shape and surrounded by more than half a dozen

smaller diamonds," Murad recalled.

It was part of a trove of 108 treasures. According to original court documents, they include a gold-and-silver sword encrusted with diamonds, a bejewelled fez with cascading pearls, and a fabulous star brooch once owned by a French empress.

History and myth

The nawab's riverside pink palace of Ahsan Manzil is now a museum.

Murad, a former popular film star, lives in a sprawling villa in a wealthy Dhaka suburb.

He flourished a sheaf of documents, including a family book with detailed paintings of the treasures.

"It is one of the most famous diamonds in the world. Its history is closely associated with that of the Koh-i-Noor," the book reports, referring to the shining centrepiece of Britain's crown jewels — a gem also claimed by Pakistan, India, Afghanistan and Iran.

"It is absolutely perfect in lustre."

Another diamond of the same name, the pink-hued Daria-i-Noor, is in Tehran as part



KHAWAJA Naim Murad, the great-grandson of the last Nawab of Dhaka, speaks during an interview at his house in the Bangladesh capital.—AFP

of Iran's former royal jewels.

Murad maintains that the family's diamond, too, was once owned by Persia's shahs, then worn by Sikh warrior-leader

Ranjit Singh in 19th-century Punjab. It was later seized by the British and eventually acquired by his ancestors.

But fortunes shifted. In 1908, the then-nawab faced financial trouble.

Sir Salimullah Bahadur borrowed from British colonial powers by mortgaging his vast Dhaka estates and placing the treasures in a vault as collateral.

That was their last confirmed sighting. Since then, myth and history merge.

Murad believes his uncle saw the jewels in the bank in the 1980s, but bank officials say they do not know if the vault has ever been opened.

Salahuddin Nagri, who chairs Bangladesh's Land Reforms Board, says the government body inherited custody of the trove, held in a state-owned bank.

"But I haven't seen any of the jewels yet," he said.

Vault is sealed

The 1908 court papers did not specify the diamond's carat weight, but valued it at

500,000 rupees — part of a hoard worth 1.8 million rupees.

By today's conversion, that equals roughly \$13 million, though experts say the market value of such rare and large jewels has since sometimes soared many times higher.

Today's guardian, Shawkat Ali Khan, managing director of Sonali Bank, said the safe remains shut.

"The vault is sealed," Shawkat Khan said. "Many years ago an inspection team came to check on the jewels, but they never really opened it. They just opened the gate that held the vault."

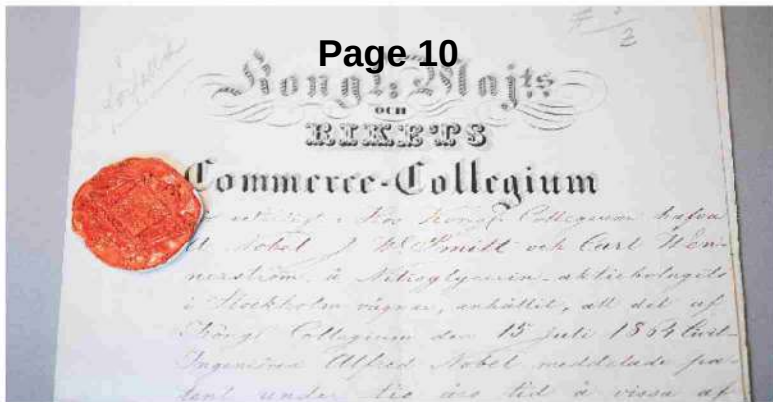
He is keen for the vault to be opened at last, though no date yet has been given.

"I am excited," he said with a brief smile.

The family hopes to discover if any of the century-old debt remains, and whether they could reclaim the jewels.

Murad dreams of diamonds, but says his real wish is to simply see the treasure for himself.

"We believe that if anyone dies in debt, his soul never finds peace."—AFP



ALFRED Nobel's patents are seen in Stockholm.—AFP

Lost for 50 years, Nobel patents found in Swedish summer home

STOCKHOLM: A dozen patents belonging to Swedish inventor and philanthropist Alfred Nobel and lost for almost 50 years were recently found in a Swedish couple's summer house, the Nobel Foundation said.

Nobel — who discovered dynamite in 1867 and created the Nobel Prizes in his 1895 will — had hundreds of patents in several countries, most of them concerning production methods and uses for explosives using nitroglycerin.

"We got a call from a person working at an auction place," the head of the Nobel Foundation, Hanna Stjarne, said.

"He had these documents that came to him from a couple in the southern part of Sweden, in Blekinge, who found those documents in their summer home. "We looked into it and saw that these are really documents of great importance that we want to keep for future generations." It is not known how the patents ended up there, but they provide a unique

glimpse into Nobel's life, Stjarne said.

"It was stunning to open these documents, to look at them, to get that feeling about what life must have been like 150 years ago, and how he travelled in Europe, how he worked in Europe." Nobel was known as a globetrotter — he was nicknamed "the richest vagabond in the world" — who at various times in his life lived in Sweden, Russia, Germany, France, the United States, Britain and Italy.

In order to protect his patents and avoid having to transport dangerous nitroglycerin long distances, the inventor founded companies in various countries. One of the patents from 1865 is of particular interest, Nobel Museum senior curator Ulf Larsson said. It is "rare in the archive because it's a very early stage in Alfred Nobel's career as an inventor," he said.

"This is a patent from a crucial stage when he had invented the detonator and was moving forward towards dynamite."—AFP

Pakistani filmmaker Saim Sadiq's *The Curfew* to screen at Venice

The short film explores identity and colonial legacies through relationship between a man and his grandmother

Dawn Report

KARACHI: A short film titled *The Curfew* will make its world premiere at the Venice Film Festival on Sept 4 (today) as the only Pakistani selection at the festival this year, *Dawn.com* reported.

Pakistan made a splash in 2019 when Saim Sadiq's film *Darling* won the Best Short Film Award at the festival.

The Curfew is a 19-minute film written and directed by Shehrezad Maher. It stars Sathya Sridharan, Balinder Johal, Sara Haider, Rajesh Bose, Chris Thorn and Salwa Khan.

The film follows the story of Ayaan, who becomes a temporary caregiver for his grandmother, following which they find themselves adrift in the

gulf of a language barrier. In the silence, specters of a colonial past shift how he sees strangers and himself.

Maher spoke to *Images* about her film, what inspired it and how fellow Pakistanis can watch it.

She said: "A 1919 photograph of an Indian man crawling at the feet of three British soldiers, a shifting understanding of my upbringing in Karachi where British supremacy was drilled into our brains at school and at home. I'm not close with, being repeatedly mistaken as service staff in stores in a New York neighbourhood, thinking about how the fumes of colonialism linger long after empire ends — shaping what we carry with us, even when the "homeland" is a glitchy diasporic hologram of other people's stories.



FILMMAKER Shehrezad Maher

Maher said: "I'm hesitant to speak for how whole generations view the world, especially on a subject as painful and varied as colonial legacies. But in the small scope of the film, Ayaan, a Pakistani American who hasn't thought deeply about his family history, is

suddenly tasked with caring for Nayyer, his Pakistani grandmother. The two characters are isolated by a language barrier, and Nayyer is feeling vulnerable and withdrawn after a recent stroke.

When memories of a colonial-era punishment grip Nayyer's dreams and cause her to sleepwalk, her charged presence within the sterile walls of Ayaan's glossy new apartment erodes Ayaan's studied apathy toward his identity and family history. Online and offline, Ayaan's interactions with strangers feel too close for comfort to the histories surfacing in Nayyer's dreams. When strangers misread him as a food delivery guy or neighbours start to police other neighbours, the lobby and the hallways of

his new building become rife with power dynamics he might have previously brushed off.

Innocuous on the surface, the encounters suggest how deeply internalised feelings of inferiority and classism, which were tools for British colonial oppression, don't evaporate upon coming to the West; they get funnelled into a different racist system.

As Ayaan's discovery and Nayyer's repression of a heavy family history surface, their relationship to the past is mirrored by their relationship to Urdu — Nayyer, through speech therapy sessions, is relearning a language she's forgotten, while Ayaan, in his somewhat doomed attempt to quickly learn Urdu, is discovering a language he's never known.

She said: "Growing up in Karachi, where reality often felt more absurd than fiction, instilled a dark sense of humor that sometimes surfaces in my work.

It also sharpened my curiosity for the surreal, the uncanny, and the unknown hiding in plain sight. Making art or film when there aren't traditionally organised structures and resources in place requires inventiveness, playfulness, and patience — skills that have expanded my comfort with creative and personal risk-taking.

My upbringing also made me restless to explore the enduring effects of British colonialism on a people's processing of memory and trauma, which happens to be an important framework for this film."

Epstein victims Page 11 compiling own list of abusers

WASHINGTON: Victims of notorious sex offender Jeffrey Epstein said Wednesday they were compiling a confidential list of his associates who abused underage girls.

President Donald Trump, a one-time close friend of the deceased financier, sought meanwhile to dampen the enduring political furor over the Epstein case. "This is a Democrat hoax that never ends," Trump told reporters at the White House.

"They're trying to get people to talk about something that's totally irrelevant to the success that we've had as a nation since I've been president," he said.

Trump's comments came as eight of Epstein's victims held an emotional news conference at the US Capitol, where some of them spoke publicly for the first time about the sexual abuse they suffered.

Some of the women were as young as 14 when introduced to Epstein.

Epstein died in a New York jail cell in 2019 while awaiting trial for sex trafficking of underage girls.

The news conference was held a day after a House of Representatives committee released 33,000 documents from the investigation into Epstein and his accomplice Ghislaine Maxwell, who is serving a 20-year prison sentence for sex trafficking.

"We were just kids," said Marina Lacerda, who said she was paid \$300 to give "an older guy" a massage at his New York mansion.

The women urged the Justice Department to release all of the Epstein investigation files and for Congress to pass a bill compelling their publication.

Many of Trump's supporters have been obsessed with the Epstein case for years and have held as an article of faith that "deep state" elites were protecting Epstein associates in the Democratic Party and Hollywood.

They were further incensed in July when the FBI and Justice Department said that Epstein had committed suicide, did not blackmail any prominent figures, and did not keep a "client list."—AFP

UN nuclear chief presses Iran to strike deal on inspections soon

VIENNA: The UN nuclear watchdog's talks with Iran on how to resume inspections at sites including those Israel and the United States bombed cannot go on for months on end, its chief said on Wednesday, pushing for a deal as early as this week.

The International Atomic Energy Agency has had no information from Iran on the status or whereabouts of its stock of highly enriched uranium since Israel launched the first attacks on its enrichment sites on June 13, IAEA chief Rafael Grossi confirmed in an interview.

Tehran has now passed a law suspending cooperation with the IAEA and stipulating any future inspections will need a green light from Iran's Supreme National Security Council. Tehran and the IAEA are now in talks on how inspections can go ahead.

"It's not something that can go on for months on end," Grossi said in an interview at IAEA headquarters in Vienna.

"Certainly hope that we can conclude this process soon. We are trying to have another meeting, perhaps within a few days now, here in Vienna, to conclude this and to start the inspections," he said. "It would be really good if we could have this agreed before next week." Technically, inspections in Iran have resumed since IAEA inspectors recently carried out a mission at Bushehr, Iran's only operating nuclear power plant, but it is of so little concern from a proliferation perspective that it does not generally feature in quarterly IAEA reports on Iran.

'By and large, nuclear material still there'

While Iran's three enrichment sites were badly damaged or destroyed in the Israeli and US bombing campaigns, it is less clear what has happened to Iran's stock of highly enriched uranium — the most sensitive material having been enriched to up to 60pc, a short step from the roughly 90pc of weapons grade.



IAEA Director General Rafael Grossi speaks during an interview in Vienna on Wednesday.—Reuters

A confidential IAEA report sent to member states on Wednesday and seen by Reuters said that on the day Israel launched its attacks Iran had slightly more material enriched to that level, 440.9 kg, than previously reported.

That is enough in principle, if enriched further, for 10 nuclear bombs, according to an IAEA yardstick. Before it was known to have nine bombs' worth at that level.

"I believe there is a general understanding that by and large, the material is still there. But, of course, it needs to be verified. Some could have been lost," Grossi said when asked about the status of Iran's highly enriched uranium stock.

"We don't have indications that would lead us to believe that there has been major movement of material," he said.

Iran has not updated the IAEA on the status of the stockpile. In the event of an agreement with the IAEA, it would have a matter of weeks to send the agency a

report accounting for it, a senior diplomat said.

How the new system under Iran's law requiring special approval by the Supreme National Security Council would work is unclear, and Iran has brought up the importance of keeping the location of its enriched uranium secret, Grossi said.

At the same time, Iran's obligations to the agency are unchanged, with Iran being told "domestic law creates obligations for Iran, not for the agency."

Room for diplomacy

The IAEA notified Iran in late July of its intention to inspect, diplomats said, and Grossi confirmed that normally it cannot let over a month pass without verifying the status of highly enriched uranium, which is refined to 20% or higher. Rather than precipitate a crisis by calling Iran out, talks continue.

"We are trying, as I've always tried ... to give way to diplomacy, to allow for a process to be put back in place. Of course, this has to be done within a certain reasonable time frame," Grossi said.

He made clear the U.S. and Israeli strikes had not eliminated Iran's ability to make more uranium-enriching machines.

With the IAEA's 35-nation Board of Governors due to meet next week, Grossi sent two reports on Iran to member states later on Wednesday making clear there had been no breakthrough.

Both reports, seen by Reuters, said an agreement paving the way for inspections to resume "should be concluded without delay" and that Iran's stock of highly enriched uranium is "a matter of serious concern".

Grossi told Reuters: "I don't lose all hope that before the board meets, we could maybe conclude." Grossi has long said he was considering running as United Nations Secretary-General next year. Asked if he was definitely going to run, he said: "Yes, I am going to do that, yes."—Reuters

Israel drops grenades near peacekeepers in Lebanon

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UN force slams drone attack

BEIRUT: The UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL) said Israeli drones dropped four grenades close to peacekeepers who were working to clear roadblocks hindering access to a UN position on Tuesday morning.

"This is one of the most serious attacks on UNIFIL personnel and assets since the cessation of hostilities agreement of last November," the UNIFIL said in a statement on Wednesday.

One grenade impacted within 20 metres and three within approximately 100 metres of UN personnel and vehicles.

UNIFIL said that the Israeli military had been informed in advance of UNIFIL's road clearance work in the area, southeast of the village of Marwahin.

Commenting on the incident, Israeli military spokesperson Lieutenant Colonel Nadav Shoshani said on X on Wednesday that troops stationed at an outpost in southern Lebanon had identified suspicious activity. They deployed several stun grenades in the vicinity "to disrupt and remove the potential threat."

He said that after a review of the event, a clarification was sent through the military liaison channel, adding that no intentional fire was directed at UNIFIL personnel and that the security of civilians and Israeli forces "remains a top priority." UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres stresses that any acts that endanger the lives of the peacekeepers are completely unacceptable, his spokesperson, Step-

hane Dujarric, said on Wednesday.

He demands that the parties uphold their responsibilities to ensure the safety and security of the peacekeepers and inviolability of UN installations. Last week, the United Nations Security Council unanimously extended the peacekeeping mission in Lebanon until the end of 2026, after which a year-long orderly and safe drawdown and withdrawal will commence.

Established in 1978, UNIFIL patrols Lebanon's southern border with Israel.

UN force slams attack

The United Nations said on Wednesday that Israeli drones dropped four grenades near UN peacekeepers in Lebanon, with Israel insisting there was "no intentional fire" at the force.

UNIFIL, the UN Interim Force in Lebanon, called Tuesday's incident "one of the most serious attacks" since a November ceasefire ended last year's war between Israel and Lebanese militant group Hezbollah.

The mission said Israeli forces had "dropped four grenades close to UNIFIL peacekeepers working to clear roadblocks hindering access to a UN position".

"One grenade impacted within 20 metres (yards) and three within approximately 100 metres of UN personnel and vehicles," it added, reporting no casualties.

The Israeli military said troops "deployed several (stun) grenades" in response to "suspicious activity", adding that "no intentional fire was directed at UNIFIL personnel".

The UN force said Israel had been informed in advance of its plans to carry out road clearance work in that

area, southeast of the border village of Marwahin.

It said endangering the lives of peacekeepers was "unacceptable and a serious violation" of a 2006 UN Security Council resolution that formed the basis of last year's ceasefire.

Under the November agreement, UNIFIL has been assisting the Lebanese army to dismantle Hezbollah military infrastructure in the south. France condemned Tuesday's incident, calling for "the protection of the peacekeepers".

Qatar called for "an urgent investigation into this attack and for those responsible to be brought to justice".

The UN Security Council voted last week for peacekeepers to leave Lebanon in 2027, allowing only one final extension of its mandate after pressure from Israel and its US ally to wind up the nearly 50-year-old force.

Last year's ceasefire stipulates that only the Lebanese army and UN peacekeepers can deploy in south Lebanon, excluding both the Israeli army and Hezbollah from the region.

However, Israel has maintained troops in five locations it deems strategic and still regularly strikes Hezbollah targets in a campaign it says will continue until the militant group has been disarmed.

Lebanon's government is expected to convene on Friday to discuss the army's plan to disarm Hezbollah, a mission the cabinet assigned it in early August.

On Wednesday, Lebanon's health ministry said Israeli strikes on southern Lebanon killed four people.

The Israeli military said one of its attacks killed Hezbollah member Al-Munim Musa Sweidan.—Agencies

Funicular accident claims three lives **Page 11**

LISBON: A famed Lisbon funicular derailed on Wednesday, leaving several people dead and injured in one of the Portuguese capital's most popular tourist spots, the president and Portuguese media said.

The media reported that at least three people died when the Gloria funicular, one of the capital's best-known symbols, overturned.

Portuguese President Marcelo Rebelo de Sousa said in a statement that several people had died and more were injured, without providing further details.

Footage from the site showed the tram-like funicular, which carries people up and down a hillside in the Portuguese capital, destroyed, and emergency workers pulling people out of the wreckage.

President Marcelo Rebelo de Sousa lamented the tragic accident in a statement, expressing hope that authorities would soon establish what had caused the crash.

The line, which opened in 1885, connects Lisbon's downtown area near the Restauradores Square with the Bairro Alto (Upper Quarter), famous for its vibrant nightlife. It is operated by the municipal public transport company Carris.—Agencies



KAOUTHER Ben Hania and Saja Kilani hold a picture of Hind Rajab during the screening of *The Voice of Hind Rajab* in competition at the Venice Film Festival.—Reuters

The Voice of Hind Rajab shakes Venice

• Docu-drama gets 24-minute ovation at the premiere • People in the audience chant ‘free, free Palestine’

VENICE: The anguished final pleas of a 5-year-old Palestinian girl trapped in a car under Israeli fire are retold in *The Voice of Hind Rajab*, a searing new film that received a rapturous premiere at the Venice Film Festival on Wednesday.

“Hind’s story carries the weight of an entire people,” one of the actors, Saja Kilani, told reporters in a statement she read out on behalf of the whole cast and crew ahead of the screening.

The true-life drama focuses on telephone operators from the Palestinian Red Crescent Society who tried for hours to reassure the trapped Hind Rajab as she begged to be rescued from the car, where her aunt, uncle and three cousins already lay dead.

“I’m so scared, please come,” the little girl says, with the original recordings of her increasingly desperate calls to the dispatchers used to powerful effect throughout the film.

“The real question is, how have we let a child beg for life? No one can live in peace while even one child is forced to plead for survival. ... Let Hind Rajab’s voice echo around the world,” Kilani said.

After a three-hour wait, the Red Crescent finally got the green light from Israel to dispatch an ambulance to save Hind. But contact with the girl and the rescuers themselves was cut just after the ambulance arrived at the scene.

Days later, the girl’s body was found along with those of her relatives in the car. The remains of the two dead ambulance workers were also recovered from their bombed-out vehicle.

The Israel Defence Forces initially said its troops had not been within firing range of the car. However, independent investigations challenged this assertion and a subsequent UN report said the IDF had destroyed Rajab’s car and killed the two medics who were trying to save her.

Asked about the killings this week, the IDF said the incident, which happened on January 29, 2024, was still under review and

declined further comment.

Standing ovation

The film received a thunderous, 24-minute standing ovation at its premiere, by far the longest of this festival to date, making it the clear crowd favourite to win the prestigious Golden Lion award, which will be awarded on Sept 6.

“Free, free Palestine,” people in the audience chanted.

The movie has also attracted some top Hollywood names as executive producers, giving it added industry heft, including actors Joaquin Phoenix and Rooney Mara, who were both in Venice on Wednesday to support the production, as well as Brad Pitt.

Tunisian director Kaouther Ben Hania, who also wrote the screenplay, said Hind’s voice transcended a single tragedy.

“When I heard the first time the voice of Hind, there was something more than her voice. It was the very voice of Gaza asking for help. ... It was anger and helplessness that gave birth to this movie,” she told reporters.

“The narrative around the world is that those dying in Gaza are collateral damage. I think this is so dehumanizing, and that’s why cinema and art are important, to give those people a voice and a face. We are saying enough, enough of this genocide,” Ben Hania said.

Genocide

The world’s biggest academic association of genocide scholars announced this week that it had passed a resolution saying the legal criteria had been met to establish that Israel is committing genocide in Gaza, something Israel denies.

The actors playing the Red Crescent dispatchers said they only heard Rajab’s recordings when they were on the set, making the filming an extremely emotional process.

“There were two times where I couldn’t keep filming. I had a panic attack,” Palestinian actor Motaz Malhees said.—Reuters

Xi offers 'war or peace' as China flexes military might

Continued from Page 1

well as the ICBMs.

Donning a tunic suit in the style worn by former leader Mao Zedong, Xi earlier greeted more than 25 leaders on the red carpet, including Indonesia's Prabowo Subianto who made a surprise appearance despite widespread protests at home.

Seated between Putin and Kim in the viewing gallery during the parade, Xi repeatedly engaged in conversations with both leaders as thousands of troops and materiel passed before them. It marked the first time the trio have appeared together in public. At a lavish reception after the parade at the Great Hall of the People, Xi told his guests that humanity must not return to the "law of the jungle".

Earlier, when Russian President Vladimir Putin walked shoulder to shoulder with Chinese President Xi Jinping, a hot mic caught them discussing organ transplants and the possibility that humans could live to 150 years old.

The moment was carried on the livestream provided by state broadcaster CCTV.

As Putin and Xi walked toward the Tiananmen rostrum where they viewed the parade with Kim, Putin's translator could be heard saying in Chinese: "Biotechnology is continuously developing."

The translator added, after an inaudible passage: "Human organs can be continuously transplanted. The longer you live, the younger you become, and (you can) even achieve immortality."

In response, Xi, who was off camera, can be heard responding in Chinese: "Some predict that in this century humans may live to 150 years old."

Kim was smiling and looking in the direction of Putin and Xi, but it was not clear if the conversation was being translated for him.

PM Shehbaz's schedule

On Wednesday, PM Shehbaz visited Beijing's Anzhen Hospital, and directed Interior Minister Mohsin

Naqvi to establish simple, robust and sustainable infrastructure at Islamabad's under-construction hospitals, including Jinnah Medical Complex, to deliver high-quality medical facilities, modelled on Chinese standards.

He also held a series of high-level meetings with senior executives of China's leading enterprises in Beijing to boost business-to-business (B2B) investment cooperation between the two countries.

The prime minister emphasized that industrial cooperation remains the cornerstone of Pakistan-China economic cooperation and a defining pillar of the high-quality development of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) as it enters into its second phase.

He invited Chinese companies to consider Pakistan as their preferred investment destination, particularly for relocating industries into Special Economic Zones.

Syed Irfan Raza in Islamabad also contributed to this report

UN seeks halt to deportations amid Afghan quake relief

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• Kunar is the worst-hit province; commandos sent to look for survivors • WFP says it has supplies, funds for only four weeks

KABUL/GENEVA: Afghanistan airdropped commandos on Wednesday to pull survivors from the rubble in areas ravaged by earthquakes that have killed more than 1,400 this week, as a United Nations agency warned that food aid for victims would run out soon without urgent funding.

Meanwhile, the UN refugee chief has called on Pakistan to pause its expulsion of Afghan refugees, as returns continued despite the weekend's deadly quake.

The latest expulsions come as already impoverished Afghanistan responds to a devastating 6.0-magnitude earthquake that wiped out villages along the border that were home to many recently expelled migrants.

More than 1,400 people were killed in the disaster. More than 1.2 million Afghans have been made to leave Pakistan since 2023, including more than 443,000 this year alone, according to the UN.

At the Chaman border crossing, "more than 4,000 people have left ever since the deadline ended", local administrator Habib Bangulzai told *AFP*.

In Spin Boldak on the Afghan side, migrant registration official Abdul Latif Hakimi estimated that "250 to 300 families are returning" daily since August 31.

At the Torkham crossing further north, more than 6,300 PoR holders returned on Tuesday alone, according to authorities managing the terminal. They estimated that nearly 63,000 PoR cardholders have entered Afghanistan since April.

Afghan refugees, some awaiting relocation overseas, reported police raids as well as extortion and harassment by authorities in the lead-up to the latest deadline.

Search and rescue

Dozens of commando forces were being airdropped at sites where helicopters cannot land, to help carry the injured to safer ground,

in what aid groups said was a race against time to rescue those still stuck under rubble.

Time was also running out for those who survived the two devastating quakes in the remote eastern region of the impoverished country, the World Food Programme (WFP) warned on Wednesday.

John Aylieff, the head of WFP in Afghanistan, told *Reuters* that the agency only has enough funding and stocks for the next four weeks.

"Four weeks is just not enough even to meet the basic, essential needs of the population struck by the earthquake, let alone put the victims on a path back to rebuilding their lives," Aylieff said.

The toll stands at 1,457 deaths, 3,394 injuries and more than 6,700 destroyed homes, the Taliban administration said. The UN has said the toll could rise, with people still trapped under rubble.

Afghanistan is prone to deadly earthquakes, particularly in the Hindu Kush mountain range, where the Indian and Eurasian tectonic plates meet.

Households wiped out

Entire households were wiped out in some villages in Kunar province, where the majority of casualties were reported from, with a dozen dead and hundreds hurt in nearby Nangarhar and Laghman provinces. Survivors sifted through rubble looking for families, carried bodies on woven stretchers and dug graves with pickaxes.

Access remained difficult, as aftershocks caused rockfall, stymieing access to already isolated villages and keeping families outdoors for fear of the remains of damaged homes collapsing on them.

Flimsy or poorly-built homes made of dry masonry, stone and timber gave little protection from the quakes, in ground left unstable by days of heavy rain, said the UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs.—Agencies

One of Imran's nephews granted bail

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By Wajih Ahmad Sheikh

LAHORE: An anti-terrorism court (ATC) on Wednesday granted post-arrest bail to Shahrez Khan, a nephew of incarcerated PTI founder Imran Khan, in a case linked to the May 9 riots.

ATC-I Judge Manzer Ali Gill allowed the bail subject to furnishing surety bonds of Rs100,000.

During the hearing, the counsel for the petitioner argued that his client had been accused of inciting workers, but the police investigation, including geo-fencing of all individuals in the case, had found no evidence against him.

He pointed out that the charge-sheet mentioned both nominated and unidentified suspects in the attack on the Lahore corps commander's residence, but the petitioner's name

was not included, adding that the investigating officer had not recorded any statement implicating his client.

The counsel alleged that the petitioner was implicated in the case on political grounds.

He also questioned the police claim of recovering a *danda* (club) from the petitioner's custody after a delay of 28 months, adding that no officer had summoned him for investigation during that period.

Opposing the plea, a prosecutor argued that photographs of Shahrez Khan had been obtained from his friends' Facebook accounts and requested the court to dismiss the bail petition.

After hearing arguments from both sides, the judge reserved the verdict.

Later in the evening, the judge announced the decision allowing the bail petition.

Israeli annexation in West Bank is 'red line', warns UAE

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• 24 Palestinians killed as military pushes further into Gaza City • UN Committee on the Rights of Persons says 21,000 children disabled in the conflict

DUBAI: The United Arab Emirates warned Israel on Wednesday that annexation in the occupied West Bank would be a "red line" that would severely undermine the Abraham Accords that normalised relations between the two countries.

The comments came as US President Donald Trump, who first brokered the accords, seeks to expand them in his current term, though efforts have stalled amid growing international criticism of Israel's conduct in the war.

The warning followed an announcement in August by Israeli far-right Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich that work would start on a long-delayed settlement intended to divide the West Bank and cut it off from East Jerusalem. Smotrich has also called for annexing the West Bank.

"From the very beginning, we viewed the Accords as a way to enable our continued support for the Palestinian people and their legitimate aspiration for an independent state," United Arab Emirates's Assistant Minister for Political Affairs and Envoy of the Minister of Foreign Affairs Lana Nusseibeh told *Reuters*. "We call on the Israeli government to suspend these [settlement] plans."

Ms Nusseibeh added that annexation "would constitute a red line for the United Arab Emirates," as it would undermine the "vision and spirit" of the accords and end the pursuit of regional integration.

The Israeli prime minister's office did not immediately respond to a request for comment. However, on Wednesday, Smotrich said maps were being drawn up for annexing territory, though it was unclear if he had Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's support.

Gaza offensive

The diplomatic friction comes as the Israeli military pushed deeper into Gaza City, with soldiers and tanks entering Sheikh Radwan, one of the urban center's most crowded neighbourhoods.

Residents said the military destroyed homes and tent encampments that housed Palestinians displaced by the war.

According to local health officials, at least 24 Palestinians, including children, were killed across Gaza, most of them in Gaza City, on Wednesday.

"Sheikh Radwan is being burnt

upside-down.

The occupation destroyed houses, burnt tents, and drones played audio messages ordering people to leave the area," said Zakeya Sami, 60.

"If the takeover of Gaza City isn't stopped, we might die, and we are not going to forgive anyone who stands and watches," she told *Reuters*.

Witnesses said the military also dropped grenades on three schools in the Sheikh Radwan area sheltering displaced families and bombed a medical clinic, destroying two ambulances.

Netanyahu has ordered the military to take the city, which he describes as the last stronghold of Hamas.

In Israel, public sentiment has increasingly favoured ending the war in a deal to release the remaining prisoners.

In Jerusalem on Wednesday, protesters climbed the roof of Israel's national library, displaying a banner that read, "You have abandoned and also killed."

Children disabled

The war's devastating toll on civilians was highlighted in a United Nations report Wednesday, which found that at least 21,000 children in Gaza have been disabled since the conflict began.

The UN Committee on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities said that of the 40,500 children who have suffered new war-related injuries, more than half have been left disabled.

The committee reported that Israeli evacuation orders were "often inaccessible" to people with hearing or visual impairments. Committee member Muhannad Al-Azzeh cited the example of a deaf mother in Rafah killed with her children, unaware of evacuation instructions.

Restrictions on humanitarian aid have disproportionately affected people with disabilities, who face severe disruptions to assistance, leaving many without food, water, or sanitation.

The committee noted that 83 per cent of disabled people have lost assistive devices like wheelchairs and walkers, which Israeli authorities often consider "dual-use items" and exclude from aid shipments.

"We can't expect children with disabilities... to be able to run and go to the (aid) points," Mr Azzeh said. "This is why one of our main recommendations is that children with disabilities must be reached out to."—Agencies

Five killed as heavy rain lashes northern India

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Yamuna river breaches danger mark in Delhi; 10,000 evacuated

NEW DELHI: Flooding across northern India killed at least five people on Wednesday, officials said, with more thunderstorms expected and local media reporting that 10,000 people have been

evacuated from the riverbanks in capital Delhi.

The monsoon season in India has been particularly intense this year, killing at least 130 people in August alone in north India, wiping out villages and destroying infrastructure.

The latest round of flooding has hit held Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Punjab, where the Chenab and Tawi rivers have risen above the

danger mark at several spots.

The swollen rivers have triggered landslides and damaged many roads, disconnecting parts of the mountainous regions of held Jammu and Himachal from the rest of India.

At least five people were killed on Wednesday after landslides battered Rajouri and Mandi districts in held Jammu and Himachal Pradesh, respectively, officials said.

The India Meteorological Department warned of heavy to very heavy rain in the region on Wednesday, with more downpours expected in Uttarakhand and Uttar Pradesh.

The Central Water Commission said the swollen Yamuna had breached its danger mark on Tuesday in Delhi. Local media reported that nearly 10,000 people had been evacuated to relief camps set up by the government along the main highways as a precautionary measure for those living in low-lying areas.

Residents living along the Yamuna in Delhi were evacuated in 2023 as well after floodwaters entered their homes and the river hit its highest level in 45 years.

Many tourist spots in Himachal Pradesh have been hit by landslides in recent weeks, as raging rivers damaged infra-

structure.

Educational institutions were ordered shut, authorities said, asking people to remain indoors due to flood warnings.

In neighbouring Punjab, the government said 30 people have been killed and nearly 20,000 evacuated since August 1.

Water gushing through the plains in India's breadbasket Punjab state has destroyed 150,000 hectares of crops, the government said on Tuesday. Continuous rain prompted authorities to release water from dams, which has caused flooding in plains in India and Pakistan in recent days.

On the other side of the border, Pakistani authorities issued an alert for more floods in the eastern heartland province of Punjab on Wednesday, after India warned it would release water downstream from its dams, officials said.

The worst floods in four decades have killed at least 43 people in Punjab, with more than 3.3 million affected since August 26, the provincial disaster management authority said.

The death toll across the country since the start of the monsoon season in late June stands at 881, according to the National Disaster Management Authority.—Reuters



NEW DELHI: Inundated homes are pictured near the banks of the overflowing Yamuna, due to monsoon rains in India's north.—AFP

Floods damaged vast areas of farmland in KP: UN-OCHA

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Report says over 80pc of people reported crop losses; 6,206 livestock lost

By Amin Ahmed

ISLAMABAD: The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs has said that 3,233 acres of agricultural land were damaged during the ongoing floods in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

The 'Rapid Needs Assessment' report prepared by UN-OCHA says Buner recorded the largest losses of agricultural land with 1,157 acres affected, followed by Swat with 853 acres, Shangla with 559 acres, and Swabi with 330 acres.

Over 80 per cent of people reported crop

losses which were significant in Battagram and Mansehra, while Lower Dir and Torghar reported smaller but notable losses, further threatening food security and livelihoods, the UN-OCHA report says.

People lost about 6,206 livestock across the affected areas of 10 districts. Buner reported the highest losses with 4,818 animals, followed by Swat with 618, Shangla with 295, Battagram with 219, and Swabi with 105. Smaller but significant losses were recorded in Bajaur, Mansehra, Torghar, and Upper Dir, while Lower Dir reported minimal impact.

The loss of livestock further weakened the livelihoods of rural households already facing crop damage and displacement.

Across most flood-affected areas, market access has remained relatively stable. Overall, 77 per cent of markets were reported as accessible, with full access in

districts such as Bajaur, Battagram, Lower Dir, Tor Ghar, and Upper Dir.

Swat and Mansehra also reported high levels of access, showing that even in areas severely hit by floods, physical access to markets was somehow maintained. However, Buner had the lowest access at only 35 per cent, leaving people there with limited options for essential supplies.

Despite this physical access, food and non-food availability in markets remains a challenge across many districts.

The regular supply of essential commodities was disrupted in 55 per cent of the affected areas, with Swabi, Shangla, and Swat facing the most significant interruptions.

This means that while people in several districts can reach markets, goods they need are often either unavailable or supplied inconsistently, affecting food security and basic household needs.

Despite considerable efforts by the KP government and humanitarian actors, the assessment data reveals that many affected people continue to face critical gaps in assistance across multiple sectors.

Food assistance reached the largest proportion of affected households at 42 per cent overall, with significant support reported in Buner, Swabi, and Shangla districts.

However, in Battagram, Lower Dir, Torghar, and Upper Dir districts, people reported no or very limited food assistance. Similarly, health services were the second-most supported sector, reaching 39 pc of the affected population.

Major health interventions were reported in Buner (82pc), Swabi (50pc), and Shangla (22pc), but Torghar and Upper Dir districts reported no health assistance at all. In terms of shelter support, only 20 per cent of households reported receiving assistance.

Districts like Swabi (50pc) and Buner (31pc) reported the highest coverage, whereas most other districts reported minimal or no assistance despite extensive housing damages. Nutrition support was reported by just 15pc of people, largely concentrated in Buner (48pc), with almost no coverage in other districts, leaving children and pregnant women at risk.

The education sector was the least supported, with only 2pc coverage, despite widespread damage to school infrastructure in districts like Buner, Swat, and Shangla, potentially impacting thousands of children.

Overall, the data highlights that while food and health received the most attention, shelter, nutrition, and education remain critically underserved, requiring targeted and sustained interventions to bridge the assistance gaps across all affected districts.